

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Friday manoeuvres may see women's bill pass?

RAHUL DATTA ■ New Delhi

The Women's Reservation Bill may not get Parliament's approval, as the ruling NDA, on its own, does not have the required numbers to get the constitutional amendments passed.

Given this scenario, the bill can pass only if the ruling dispensation can garner support from other parties or persuade some of them to abstain. Voting will take place on Friday in the Lok Sabha at 4 pm.

And in another scenario, if the Bill is not passed, BJP leaders said that the opportunity may be exploited by the ruling dispensation to 'expose' the Opposition that they are against women's reservation. "The party strategist might have taken a very calculated risk in this matter, hence they convened the three-day additional sittings of the Budget session just ahead of the crucial assembly elections in

West Bengal and Kerala," said a BJP Parliamentarian.

A point to ponder is that if the numbers are stacked against the NDA, why did it risk introducing the bills now? Whether the ruling BJP has an ace up its sleeve or it goes all out to corner the Opposition, branding them anti-women if the bill is defeated, will only be known on Friday evening.

However, there are certain options under which the bills can be passed in the Lok Sabha. The bills, including the Constitutional Amendment Bill, could get approval from the Lok Sabha if at least two main opposition parties, such as the Samajwadi Party, the Trinamool Congress, or the DMK, abstain from voting.

The other scenario indicated cross-party backing, meaning some Opposition or independent members cross-vote in favour of the NDA, for the bill to go through.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



ABHINAV KUMAR JHA ■ Noida

The smoke from Monday's arson has cleared. The stones have stopped flying. Yet, by Thursday, as you walk through the industrial sectors of Noida, what you find is not calm. Instead, it is the particular stillness of a place holding its breath.

Police pickets stand at every significant junction in Sector 63 and the surrounding blocks. Constables in riot gear sit on plastic chairs outside factory gates that are either shut or half-open. The roads, usually choked with workers, are thin with traffic. The district looks like a town that had a bad week and is not yet sure the week is over.

Uncertainty lingers. "There is an atmosphere of fear here," said a worker outside a factory in Sector 63's B Block, glancing at the police post nearby. "As long as the police are here, things are quiet. The moment they leave, trouble will start again." He did not reveal his name.

This is the mood four days after over 40,000 factory workers poured onto Noida's streets, blocked key roads, and clashed with police across 80 locations in what began as a protest over wages and quickly turned into a day of fire and stone-throwing. More than 60 people have been arrested. The Uttar Pradesh govern-

Names cleared by tribunals to vote in WB: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday ordered that voters in West Bengal, who are cleared by appellate tribunals for inclusion in electoral rolls at least two days before the elections, will be entitled to vote in the upcoming State Assembly elections.

A Bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi passed the order in the exercise of the Court's inherent powers under Article 142 of the Constitution of India.

Polls in West Bengal are scheduled to be held in two phases — on April 23 and April 29. As per the order, those who are cleared by appellate tribunals on or before April 21 or April 27,



as the case maybe, will be entitled to vote in the upcoming elections. After observing a trust deficit between the Election Commission and the West

Bengal Government, the apex court had on February 20 ordered the deployment of district judges and additional district judges, including retired judges, for the smooth conduct of the SIR.

Around 900 judicial officers were engaged for the purpose. These officers decided upon about 60 lakh objections, and around 27 lakh stood excluded from the rolls. The Supreme Court also directed the establishment of appellate tribunals to consider appeals from those who wish to challenge the decisions of judicial officers. Around 19 appellate tribunals are now functional and are hearing appeals against the decision of judicial officers.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

LeT co-founder shot at in Lahore

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

Amir Hamza, the co-founder of banned Pakistan-based terror outfit Lashkar-e-Tayyiba (LeT) and its second-most important leader after Hafiz Saeed, was injured in a targeted shooting incident on Thursday evening near a Pindi shop in Lahore, Pakistan.

Unidentified gunmen on a motorcycle opened fire on a white car carrying Hamza and a retired judge, Nazir Ahmed Ghazi, who hosts a religious programme on a



private TV channel. Hamza was rushed to a nearby hospital and is said to be undergoing treatment.

Interestingly, in May last year, Hamza suffered

serious injuries in an attack carried out by a LeT operative holding personal grudge against him.

According to Lahore police, two armed men fired at the vehicle near Peco Road on Thursday, close to the office of 24NewsHD TV channel, which is owned by Pakistan Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi.

Hamza sustained bullet injuries to his arm while Justice (Retd) Nazir Ahmed Ghazi remained unhurt. Lahore Police have launched an investigation and are examining CCTV

footage to identify the attackers. Authorities have not yet revealed whether the attack was linked to internal rivalries, personal enmity, or larger intra-feuds among Lashkar cadres.

According to available information, the TV channel confirmed the incident in a statement on X. Ghazi had just finished recording his show 'Noor-e-Sehar' and was heading home when the attack occurred. Hamza, who had appeared as a guest on the programme, was travelling with him.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Amidst peace, uncertainty lingers on Noida Sector 63 streets



ment has said 45 of the 66 arrested were not factory workers, and has alleged that external elements orchestrated the violence

area, said the immediate trigger was straightforward. "Every year, the company used to raise salaries by about ₹500 a month. This year, they have not increased it. That is what started the protest." He said work has not resumed at his factory. "In some nearby companies, a few workers have come back. But many have still not returned."

A man who works as a cleaner in one of the sector's units earns ₹11,000 a month for an eight-hour shift. He pays ₹4,000 in rent. "How do we survive on what is left?" he asked. He was not at the protest. He said he cannot afford to lose a day's wage.

A migrant worker from

Samastipur in Bihar, who gave his name as Suman, described the day of violence as overwhelming and leaderless.

"There were so many people. It was completely mixed, workers from all kinds of companies together. It could happen again any time," he said. He added, with a tired laugh, that the money was so little he sometimes thought people would be better off selling goods from a cart on the street, if only the local committees did not harass street vendors.

The revised wage structure that triggered the unrest took effect on April 1, raising minimum monthly salaries by up to 21 per cent for workers in Noida and

Ghaziabad. But on the ground, it has not yet arrived. "The government has said salaries have been increased," one worker said. "But the company has not increased anything. No notice has come from the company. If they do not increase it, there will be violence again."

Lalit Thukral, president of the Noida Apparel Export Cluster, has said rising input costs make it difficult for exporters to absorb the wage hike. "Our margins are already under pressure, and buyers are renegotiating to lower prices. If we do not comply, they will shift orders to Bangladesh, Cambodia, or Vietnam," he said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



GOOGLE BLOCKED OVER 24m ADVT ACCOUNTS

Tech giant Google blocked or removed 483.7 million policy-violating advertisements and suspended 1.7 million advertiser accounts in India in 2025 with the help of its AI platform Gemini. Globally, Google blocked or removed over 8.3 billion bad ads and suspended 24.9 million advertiser accounts last year, according to Google's '2025 Ads Safety Report' released on Thursday. The company stated that the integration of its Gemini artificial intelligence models has dramatically improved its ability to detect and stop bad actors in real-time, especially as scammers increasingly use generative AI to create deceptive ads at scale.

MODI, MACRON DISCUSS WEST ASIA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke with French President Emmanuel Macron and discussed the situation in West Asia, with both leaders emphasising the need to urgently restore safety and freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz. In a post on X about his telephonic conversation with Macron, Prime Minister Modi said on Thursday, "We will continue our close cooperation to advance peace and stability in the region and beyond."



A SpiceJet plane taxiing at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport Terminal 1 struck a stationary Akasa aircraft on Thursday around 2.15 pm, causing damage to both the planes.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has initiated a probe into the incident. Both Boeing 737 aircraft have been grounded at the airport after the incident. An Air Traffic Controller official and the SpiceJet pilots have been derostered.

Akasa Air's plane was to operate flight QP 1406 from Delhi to Hyderabad, while the SpiceJet aircraft had arrived from Leh after operating the flight SG 124.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

A total of 1,88,460 students appeared in the examination this year, of whom 1,83,240 passed. Among individual achievers, 26 students scored 95 per cent and above, 540 students scored between 90 per cent and 95 per cent, and 5,202 students scored between 80 per cent and 90 per cent.

Police arrest man for duping over 500 women of ₹2 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Doctor, lawyer, film producer, model, businessman — behind many online personas is a 35-year-old man who allegedly duped over 500 women across the country of more than ₹2 crore by using fake social media or dating app profiles, emotional stories and promises of marriage to lure victims into his trap.

The accused, Anand Kumar, was arrested by a team of southwest cyber police for allegedly running an organised network of romance scams, honey-trapping and online blackmail targeting women through dating and matrimonial platforms, Deputy Commissioner of

Police (Southwest) Amit Goel said in a statement.

Kumar used multiple fake identities on various social media platforms as well as on dating and matrimonial applications to approach unsuspecting women.

“He would present himself as a well-settled professional with an impressive background, often claiming to be a doctor, businessman or film producer to gain credibility and attract victims,” the DCP said.

According to investigators, the accused would initiate friendly conversations and gradually build emotional connections with the victims over days or weeks. After establishing trust, he would shift communication to private messaging platforms,

using multiple mobile numbers to avoid detection.

“The accused carefully crafted his ‘personas’ and maintained parallel conversations with several victims at the same time. He exploited emotional vulnerabilities and created a sense of intimacy to manipulate victims into trusting him,” he added.

The officer said once he gained the victim’s confidence, Kumar would introduce fabricated narratives, including urgent medical emergencies, business losses, family crises or financial setbacks, to solicit money.

In several instances, he also promised marriage or lucrative opportunities such as modelling assignments or admissions to reputed institutions as a means to lure victims.



“In one case, a woman was allegedly cheated of around ₹7 lakh after being contacted by a fake profile operating under the name Vaibhav Arora. The accused initially befriended her on a dating app and later developed a romantic relationship, promising marriage. He further strengthened his deception by introducing another fictitious identity, claiming it to be his friend who would help formalise their relationship,” the officer said.

Police said Kumar subse-

quently fabricated stories of financial distress and sought monetary assistance from the victim.

When she began demanding her money back, he stopped responding and later falsely claimed that the person she knew had died, in an attempt to cut off communication and evade suspicion.

An FIR into the matter was registered, and further investigation was launched. A team scanned the money trail, bank accounts and technical analysis to trace the accused. The accused was apprehended from West Bengal on March 22.

The investigation also suggested that apart from financial fraud, the accused also allegedly engaged in extortion by exploiting private

content shared by victims.

During online interactions, he would persuade women to share personal photos or videos, which he later used to threaten them with exposure on social media platforms if they refused to pay money, police said.

They said Kumar operated with a “high level of sophistication”, using multiple mobile phones and SIM cards obtained under different identities. He frequently switched devices and accounts to avoid being traced, making it difficult for law enforcement agencies to track his activities.

During interrogation and examination of his devices, police found that he was simultaneously operating numerous fake identities and

communicating with victims across multiple states.

“Technical analysis revealed that the accused had targeted more than 500 women and cheated or extorted approximately ₹2 crore,” the officer said, adding that he had previous involvement in similar cases in Delhi and Ghaziabad. Police also recovered four smartphones, eight SIM cards, three debit cards and gold jewellery, including bracelets and chains, allegedly purchased using the proceeds of crime.

“Significant portion of the defrauded money was spent on online gaming and personal expenses. Further investigation is underway to identify additional victims and trace the financial trail of the fraud,” the officer added.

Govt to equip four ITIs with high-tech labs to train youngsters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will equip its four industrial training institutes (ITIs) with high-tech labs to train youngsters in power electronics, electric vehicles and the automotive sector. As part of the plan, a dedicated power electronics lab will be established at ITI Jahangirpuri.

It will offer advanced training in power electronics, electrical control systems, industrial automation and renewable energy, said a Delhi Chief Minister Office (CMO) statement.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the initiative marks a significant step towards building a skilled, industry-ready workforce. “These modern labs will not only enhance technical capabilities but also give trainees exposure to real-world industrial practices, opening up opportunities for both employment and self-employment,” she said. The move aligns with



These modern labs will not only enhance technical capabilities but also give trainees exposure to real-world industrial practices, opening up opportunities for both employment and self-employment

— REKHA GUPTA, CHIEF MINISTER

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of Skill India and a technologically empowered youth, contributing to economic growth and self-reliance, she added.

It will be equipped with modern systems such as Programmable Logic Controller (PLC) kits, Variable Frequency Drive (VFD) train-

ers, transformer trainers, motor control panels, relay and protection systems, solar PV training kits and smart energy monitoring systems.

The lab will provide trainees with hands-on experience in operating, diagnosing faults and maintaining modern electrical and power electronics systems.

It is expected to evolve into a centre of excellence in power engineering, aligning training closely with industry requirements. Trainees from trades including electrician, electronics mechanic, mechanic auto electrical and electronics (MAEE), solar technician, fitter, mechanic refrigeration and air conditioning (MRAC) and mechanic motor vehicle (MMV) will benefit. A total of 480 trainees can be trained in these trades.

At ITI Jail Road (Hari Nagar), the existing welder lab will undergo a comprehensive upgrade. The modernised facility will feature advanced welding machines, simulation-based training systems and contemporary fabrication tools, enabling trainees to gain real-world exposure to industrial welding processes.

The upgraded lab will include arc welding, MIG/TIG welding, gas cutting, plasma cutting, welding simulators and metal fabrication workstations. This will help trainees build precision,

strengthen safety awareness and develop industry-relevant fabrication skills.

The initiative is also expected to expand apprenticeship and employment opportunities while transforming the facility into an advanced welding training hub aligned with modern manufacturing standards. Around 200 trainees from trades such as welder, fitter, turner, mechanic motor vehicle and sheet metal worker will benefit.

Automotive labs at ITI Arab Ki Sarai (Nizamuddin) will also be upgraded with cutting-edge technology. A key highlight is the introduction of high-end Virtual Reality (VR) simulators for training in driving, welding and painting.

These simulators will allow trainees to learn complex skills in a safe, controlled and highly realistic environment. In addition, specialised modules on advanced vehicle systems such as Anti-lock Braking Systems (ABS) and airbags will be introduced.

LG orders immediate fix for seepage, lift issues at Swabhiman Apartments

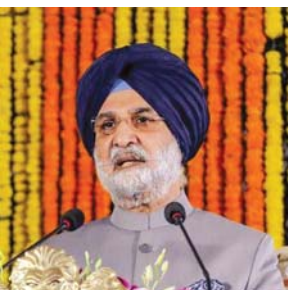
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Sandhu on Thursday directed officials to address issues faced by residents of the Swabhiman Apartments, including seepage in some flats, garbage management, irregular functioning of lifts in a few towers, and problems caused by miscreants in the area.

The directions came after Sandhu visited the housing complex developed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) at Jailorwala Bagh, Ashok Vihar, and interacted with residents in the spirit of citizen-centric governance.

The project is one of the flagship housing initiatives aimed at realising the vision of “Jahan Jhuggi, Wahin Makan” of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Taking immediate cogni-



sance of the issues flagged by the resident, the Lt Governor issued clear directions to the DDA, the district administration, and the Delhi Police to address the concerns on priority and ensure that the residents receive a safe, clean, and well-maintained living environment.

During the visit, the residents expressed their gratitude to the prime minister for enabling them to move from informal settlements into permanent homes with improved civic amenities.

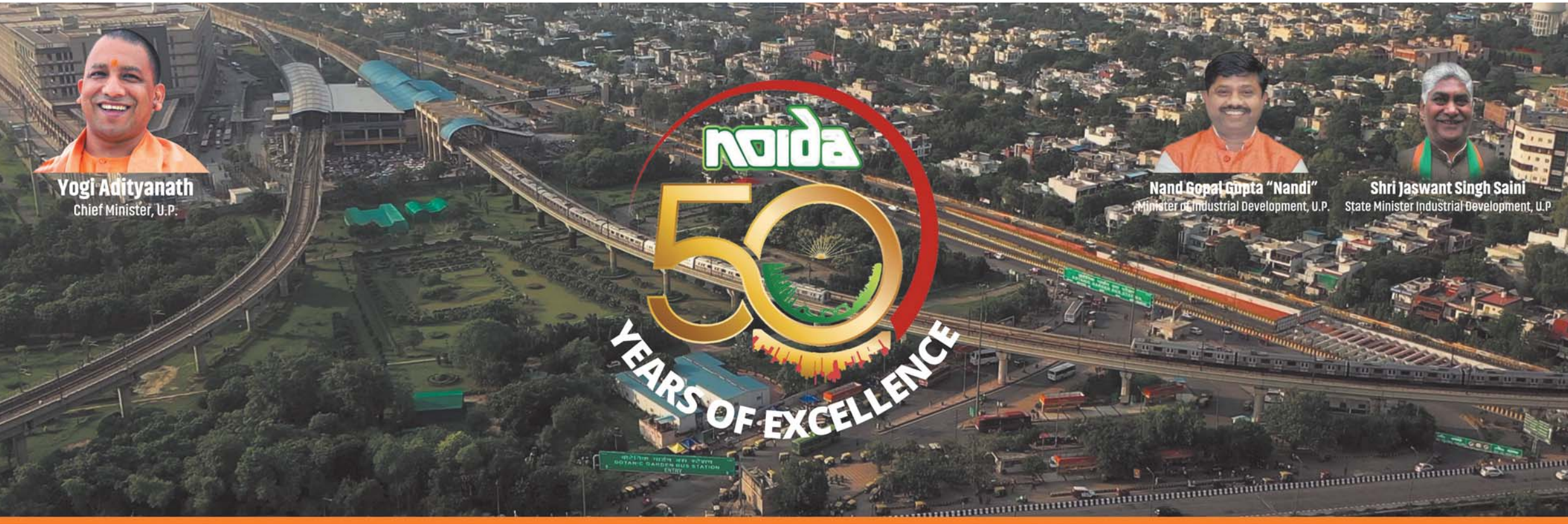
The Swabhiman Apartments comprise modern pucca multi-storey residential units with ownership rights, designed to provide dignified and secure housing to residents from economically weaker sections. The project marks a significant step toward improving the quality of life for marginalised communities and reflects the Government’s commitment to inclusive urban development.

Sandhu emphasised that the Swabhiman Apartments represent transformative infrastructure, and poor maintenance must not be allowed to undermine such landmark initiatives.

The project has the potential to serve as a replicable model for similar housing initiatives across the country, contributing to the broader vision of building a Viksit Delhi and Viksit Bharat.



Yogi Adityanath
Chief Minister, U.P.



Noida
50
YEARS OF EXCELLENCE



Nand Gopal Gupta “Nandi”
Minister of Industrial Development, U.P.



Shri Jaswant Singh Saini
State Minister Industrial Development, U.P.

A Vision Realised. A Future Reimagined.

Among India’s best-planned cities, Noida stands as a vision realised, blending world-class infrastructure with green, spacious living. Clean, vibrant and opportunity-rich, Noida remains a preferred destination for all. At 50, Noida looks ahead with renewed resolve, shaping a future that reflects people’s aspirations – I Love Noida.



Noida @ 50
Established in 1976, Noida is a benchmark of integrated city development.



Meticulously Planned
Total Area 20,316 hectares.
Planned Area 15,316 hectares.



Seamless metro connectivity
29.7 km Aqua Line (21 stations) with strong Delhi Metro links.



Smooth city mobility
11 underpasses, 6 flyovers, 8 bridges, 31 FOBs.



Smart traffic system
High-speed ITMS on Noida Expressway.



Global corporate hub
Hosting massive investment from world’s leading companies.



Industrial & IT growth
Major investments up to ₹1 lac crore.



Apparel powerhouse
3,000+ units | Rs 55,000 cr annual production | Rs 45,000 cr exports | 10 lakh+ jobs



Power ready for future
98 electric substations operational | 14 electric substations under progress | 1,12,574 LED lights installed across city



Strong water systems
406 MLD supply + 260 MLD Ganga water | 8 STPs with 411 MLD capacity.



Green cityscape
1401.28 acres of well-maintained parks | 1071.07 acres of green belt | 802.18 km Road Kilometer tree plantation | 258.83 km dust-free road



Smart civic services
Door-to-door waste collection across 168 sectors | Digital governance | Single-window clearances.

IN FOCUS



A woman covering herself and her child on a hot summer day during her visit to Taj Mahal in Agra, Uttar Pradesh

Hardik Shah appointed private secretary to PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

IAS officer Dr Hardik Satish Chandra Shah of the 2010 Gujarat cadre has been appointed as the personal secretary to Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the level of joint secretary in the Prime Minister's Office (PMO).

The appointment has been made on a coterminous basis, meaning his tenure will continue alongside that of the Prime Minister. Dr Shah, who has been associated with the PMO since 2019, will now officially hold this position until May 31, 2029.

This is not a new responsibility for Dr Shah, as he has already been serving in this role since August 17, 2020. His formal elevation follows his selection to the rank of joint Secretary or equivalent

in February 2026, further strengthening his position within the PMO.

Dr Shah began his journey in the Prime Minister's Office as a deputy secretary between 2019 and 2020, where he became part of the core administrative team involved in high-level policy coordination and governance. Before joining the Indian Administrative Service, Dr Shah worked as a junior engineer with the Gujarat Pollution Control Board (GPCB). Over the years, he has held several important administrative roles in Gujarat, building a reputation for his expertise and efficiency. His appointment is seen as a recognition of his experience and contribution to governance at the highest level, as he continues to play a key role in supporting the Prime Minister's office.

Over 700 BJP candidates elected unopposed ahead of Gujarat local body election, claims party chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Ahead of the upcoming local self-Government elections in Gujarat scheduled for April 26, the BharatiyaJanata Party (BJP) has claimed a significant political advantage, with around 700 of its candidates elected unopposed across the state.

State BJP president Jagdish Vishwakarma described the development as unprecedented, stating that such a large number of uncontested victories had not been



witnessed in Gujarat's electoral history before. He attributed this outcome to the strong public confidence in the party among the state's 65 million residents. The final day for withdrawal of nominations saw dramatic scenes

Delhi CM meets Rajasthani community in Coimbatore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Coimbatore/New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday interacted with members of the Rajasthani community in Coimbatore, praising their contribution to economic growth and describing their journey as a strong example of resilience and enterprise.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said that the Rajasthani community has played a significant role in Tamil Nadu's development through sustained efforts in trade and industry. She said their hard work has not only strengthened businesses but also supported the state's broader economic framework. The Chief Minister expressed appreciation for the warm welcome extended to her and said she was pleased to engage with fam-



ilies who have lived in Coimbatore for decades. She noted that many members of the community have been settled in the city for over 50 years, with newer generations born and raised there. She said their commitment and determination have helped shape Coimbatore's growth over time.

Highlighting the commu-

nity's cultural background, the Chief Minister said that courage and determination are central to Rajasthan's identity and are reflected in the lives of those settled in other parts of the country. She also acknowledged women's role in the community, describing them as equally strong and determined. Speaking on governance and development,

the Chief Minister said economic progress depends heavily on trade and industrial activity.

She explained that tax revenue generated through such activities enables Governments to invest in infrastructure, including roads, flyovers, schools, colleges, and hospitals. She said development is supported by both local tax systems and assistance from the Central Government.

Referring to national policies, the Chief Minister said that under the leadership of Narendra Modi, there has been a strong push for entrepreneurship and ease of doing business.

She said the Centre has worked towards balanced development across regions, from southern to northern states and from western to northeastern parts of the country.

Lion of Ladakh honoured with full State military rites

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The final rites of the Lion of Ladakh, Colonel (Retd) Sonam Wangchuk, were performed with full state honours in the presence of senior Army officers, family members and a large number of people from different walks of life in Leh on Thursday. The Lieutenant Governor of the Union Territory of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, also attended the funeral ceremony. He laid a wreath and paid rich tributes to the decorated Kargil War hero.

The jawans of the Ladakh Scouts accorded Col. Wangchuk a Guard of Honour in recognition of his distinguished service to the nation. Recipient of



India's second-highest wartime gallantry award, Col (Retd) Wangchuk died of cardiac arrest at 61 at his residence in Leh on Friday.

The late Colonel Sonam Wangchuk played a pivotal role in India's victory during

the 1999 Kargil War. As a young officer, he led daring operations under extremely challenging conditions in the high-altitude battlegrounds, displaying exceptional bravery, leadership, and tactical acumen. His

courageous actions and steadfast commitment significantly contributed to the success of Indian forces, earning him the prestigious Maha Vir Chakra (MVC), the country's second-highest wartime gallantry award. Expressing deep grief, the lieutenant governor said he was profoundly saddened by the demise of Col. Sonam Wangchuk, whose valour during the Kargil War brought immense pride to the nation and Ladakh. He stated that the late officer's indomitable courage, dedication, and service to the country would continue to inspire generations.

The Lieutenant Governor extended his heartfelt condolences to the bereaved family and prayed for strength for them in this

hour of grief. He had also visited the family yesterday to personally convey his sympathies and pay his respects.

Paying homage to the "Lion of Ladakh", the Lieutenant Governor had announced that the UT Administration will establish a befitting memorial in Leh in honour of the late Col. Sonam Wangchuk, in consultation with the family, the Indian Army, and local representatives. He stated that the memorial would serve as an enduring symbol of Ladakhi valour and pride.

The lieutenant governor affirmed that the legacy and bravery of late Colonel Sonam Wangchuk will forever remain a source of inspiration for future generations.

SIA files chargesheet in Doctors Terror Module case

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

The State Investigation Agency (SIA), Kashmir, on Thursday filed a chargesheet before the competent court in a significant terror conspiracy case linked to the clandestine "Doctors Terror Module".

The charge sheet has been filed against ten (10) accused persons in connection with an FIR registered at Police Station Nowgam, Srinagar.

Those chargesheeted include Arif Nisar Dar, Yasir Ul Ashraf Bhat, Maqsood Ahmad Dar, Irfan Ahmad Wagay, Zameer Ahmad Ahanger, Dr Muzamil Shakeel Ganale, Dr Adeel Ahmad Rather, Dr Shaheen Saeed, Tufail Ahmad Bhat, Dr Umar Un Nabi.

According to a statement issued by the State Investigation Agency, through a comprehensive, evidence-driven investigation, SIA has successfully dismantled the entire terrorist network and its support



structure. The investigation has unearthed clinching and irrefutable evidence, comprising recoveries, digital forensics, scientific analysis, and corroborative witness accounts, which firmly establish the complicity, active participation, and coordinated roles of each accused in the conspiracy.

The SIA spokesman said, "The material brought on record not only exposes the depth and spread of the module. A substantial body of evidence has thus been collected, clearly establishing a strong prima facie case against the accused".

Gujarat leads India's growth story, says CM



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat continues to position itself as a leading force in India's economic growth", Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel said while inaugurating a three-day Annual Trade Expo organised by the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry (GCCCI) in Gandhinagar.

Addressing the gathering, Patel emphasised that Gujarat has emerged as a development role model through the synergy of trade and tradition, commerce and culture, as well as industry and entrepreneurship.

He highlighted that the state contributes 8.3 per cent to the country's GDP and 18 per cent to its industrial output, underscoring its economic strength. The "Gujarat Advanced Technology and Economy Expo 2026", being held from April 16 to 18 at the Exhibition Centre, spans over 18,000 square metres and features participation from more than 16 sectors.

25,000 register for Amarnath Yatra as J&K chief secretary reviews preparations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jammu

Amid heavy rush at registration counters in Jammu, over 25,000 pilgrims have so far enrolled for the annual yatra to the Amarnath cave shrine, located at an altitude of 3,880 metres in the Himalayan ranges of south Kashmir.

Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo on Thursday reviewed arrangements for the yatra and set June 20 as the deadline for putting key facilities in place.

The registration for the 57-day pilgrimage to the cave shrine began on April 15, drawing enthusiastic devotees in large numbers to bank branches and online plat-



forms. Officials said more than 25,000 pilgrims have registered over the past two days, including 19,402 registrations on the first day alone.

FROM PAGE - 1

landed and was taxiing while the Air India aircraft was waiting on the taxiway before departure.

Names cleared by tribunals to vote...

The Supreme Court directed the Election Commission of India that appellate tribunal orders passed by April 21 (where polling is scheduled on April 23) or April 27 (where polling is scheduled on April 29) must be given effect to by issuing a supplementary revised electoral roll.

"We, therefore, invoke our powers under Article 142 of the Constitution of India and direct the ECI that, wherever the Appellate Tribunals can decide the appeals by 21.04.2026 or 27.04.2026, as the case may be, such appellate orders shall be given effect to by issuing a supplementary revised electoral roll, and all necessary consequences with respect to the right to vote shall follow. However, it goes without saying that the mere pendency of appeals preferred by excluded persons before the Appellate Tribunals shall not entitle them to exercise their right to vote," the April 13 order stated.

Friday manoeuvres may see ...

The introduction of three Bills aimed at advancing women's reservation to 2029 — the Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026; the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026; and the Delimitation Bill, 2026 was taken up on Thursday in the lower house following a simple division of votes.

The exercise indicated how the numbers may stack up when the key legislation to amend the Constitution is taken up for a special division at 4 pm on Friday.

Coming to the rules, any Bill to amend the Constitution must be passed by both Houses of Parliament with a special majority (two-thirds) of over 50 per cent members present in the House. By demanding a division of votes to

ascertain whether the Lok Sabha approved the introduction of the three Bills, the Opposition appeared to be testing waters on its numerical strength. The bill was later introduced with 251 members supporting it and 185 members voting against. As regards the nitty-gritty of voting on Friday to pass the bills, the NDA has the support of 293 members in the Lok Sabha, which is 54 per cent of the house, and the opposition has 233 MPs.

While seven MPs are independents, seven belong to parties such as YSRCP, AIMIM, and Shiromani Akali Dal, which have yet to support the bills openly.

The rules require 360 MPs to support the bills, including the Constitution amendment bill, which comes to two-thirds of those present and voting.

For the bills to get approval from the Lok Sabha, at least two main opposition parties, namely the Samajwadi Party (37 MPs), the Trinamool Congress (28 MPs), or the DMK (22 MPs), would have to abstain. The Congress has 98 MPs in the Lok Sabha.

On the other hand, the BJP has 240 MPs, TDP 16 and JDU 12 in the Lok Sabha from the NDA. If the bills do not get the Lok Sabha nod, they will not be taken up in the Rajya Sabha.

In the Rajya Sabha, the NDA has 141 members in their favour, which is 58 per cent of the upper house, and the opposition has 83 MPs in support.

Parties such as the BRS, YSRCP, BJD, BSP and independents have 20 MPs in the Upper house, and their votes may help swing the decision.

For the Constitution amendment bill to get through the Upper house, the ruling alliance needs the support of 163 MPs present and voting, which is two-thirds majority of the house. While the BJP has 107 MPs in the Rajya Sabha, the Congress has 28, the TMC 13, the AAP 10, and the DMK 8.

Amending the Constitution requires a special majority in both houses of Parliament: a majority of the total membership (more than 50 per cent) and a two-thirds majority of members present and voting. So if all 540 members currently in the house are present and voting, the two-thirds majority would be 360.

Back women's bill or face backlash: PM Modi

"I want to say from this House today with a great sense of responsibility that whether it is the south, the north, the east, the west, small states or big states, this decision-making process will not discriminate against any state or do injustice to anyone," he said.

Modi also made it clear that the number of Lok Sabha seats in any state will not decrease as a result of the delimitation exercise.

"There will be no change in that proportion (of Lok Sabha seats) either, and the increase will also be in the same proportion," he said.

Modi also said the ruling dispensation does not want credit for implementing the women's reservation law in 2029 and offered to give credit to the opposition. He said the women of this country have not forgiven those who had opposed giving this right to women in the past; they have faced the consequences.

Modi said that when Parliament was discussing the women's reservation legislation in 2023, people were saying to "hurry up", which, however, couldn't happen in 2024. "Now in 2029, we have time. If we don't do it even in 2029, we can imagine what the situation will be like. The time demands that we should not delay any further now," he said.

Opposition doubts Govt intent

She said the bill talks of increasing the number of Lok Sabha seats to up to 850 — to be done by a delimitation commission based on the 2011 Census data.

She said it was Rajiv Gandhi, as prime minister, who brought a bill for women's reservation in panchayats and nagarpalikas, and that the bill was finally passed during the PV Narasimha Rao government of the Congress.

Taking a swipe at Modi, she said that, from the prime minister's address, it seems the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is a champion of women's reservation. "Any woman would tell

you that women easily recognise those who try to mislead them," she said and urged the BJP to be careful.

Congress leader Shashi Tharoor lashed out at the government for linking women's reservation with delimitation, saying the Opposition will not allow "political demonetisation". Speaking with reporters outside the Parliament House complex, Tharoor said the government can immediately implement women's reservation by delinking it from delimitation, and that the Opposition would support the move.

SpiceJet clips Akasa planes' wing on T1

The right winglet of SpiceJet was damaged and the left-hand horizontal stabiliser of Akasa was hit.

This incident comes against the backdrop of several other safety-related events at Delhi airport in recent months.

FlightRadar24 playback indicates that the incident occurred when the SpiceJet aircraft from Leh was pulling into the gate, and Akasa Air's aircraft was pushing back for Hyderabad.

"Preliminary information indicates that Akasa's aircraft was stationary when another airline's aircraft made contact with it. All passengers and crew were safely disembarked, and our ground teams are making alternative arrangements to fly our passengers to Hyderabad at the earliest," Akasa Airlines said in a statement.

In a statement, SpiceJet said its Boeing 737-700 aircraft was involved in a ground occurrence while taxiing at Delhi airport, resulting in damage to its right winglet and the left-hand horizontal stabiliser of another aircraft from a different airline.

According to officials, the wings of both aircraft came in contact on the taxiway. Taxiway collisions, while less dramatic than in-flight incidents, are considered serious events in aviation safety protocols.

A similar incident occurred on February 3, when an IndiGo aircraft made wingtip contact with an Air India plane at Mumbai airport. At the time of the incident, the IndiGo aircraft had

LS seats in southern States to increase from 129 to 195: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said a “completely false” narrative is being spread that the representation of southern States will go down in the Lok Sabha after its strength is increased to 816 seats following the implementation of women’s reservation and delimitation of constituencies.

Intervening in the debate in Lok Sabha on the three bills introduced for amendment of the women’s quota law and to set up a delimitation commission, Shah said the fact is that the number of seats will go up and power will grow.

He said the number of Lok Sabha seats in the five southern States will go up from the

FROM 543 SEATS TO 816 (50% INCREASE)				
No.	State	Current Seats (543)	Current % of 543 Seats	50% Increase (Approx.)
1.	Karnataka	28	5.15%	42
2.	Andhra Pradesh	25	4.60%	38
3.	Telangana	17	3.13%	26
4.	Tamil Nadu	39	7.18%	59
5.	Kerala	20	3.68%	30
Total		129	23.76% (Approx. 24%)	195
				23.87% (Approx. 24%)

present 129 to 195 seats, while the percentage of power will increase from 23.76 per cent to 23.87 or almost 24 per cent. “Lok Sabha seats in Karnataka will increase to 42 from the present 28; in Andhra Pradesh, the number of Lok Sabha sets will increase to 38 from 25; in Telangana, it will be 26 from present 17; in Tamil Nadu, the number of

Lok Sabha seats will go up to 59 from the present 39; and in Kerala, it will be 30 seats from the present 20,” he said. Shah strongly rejected the opposition suggestion that the Government will indulge in some kind of “mischief” during the delimitation exercise, saying the NDA Government has not made any changes in the existing



law. “The delimitation bill is exactly like the previous law brought by your Government. There is no change, not even a comma or a full stop,” he said. Explaining how the total number of seats in the new Lok Sabha is fixed at 816, the home minister said it is exactly 50 per cent more than the current total seats.

Will move SC against delimitation bill, if passed in Parliament: DMK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The DMK on Thursday said that it will move the Supreme Court against the delimitation bill, if it is passed in the Parliament.

While releasing the DMK’s Assembly election campaign song, the party’s legal department secretary, NR Elango, said that the legal option is always open. “We will take legal steps in the interest of the southern States,” he added.

However, he wondered if the bill could be passed in the Parliament and get the presidential assent. Adding to Elango’s statement, DMK Organising Secretary RS Bharathi said, “We have full confidence in the Supreme Court. We also have valid grounds to move the court”. With regard to the assurance given by Union Minister Amit Shah in the Parliament,



DMK MLA and Thousand Lights constituency candidate, Ezhilan, along with party workers hold black flags and raise slogans during a protest against the proposed Delimitation bill, outside Karunanidhi’s residence in Chennai, Tamil Nadu on Thursday

he said, “Oral assurance will not give confidence. The bill should have clarification, but it was not there. No guarantee was given”.

Claiming that the delimitation Bill will not be passed in the Parliament, Bharathi said both Tamil Nadu and West Bengal have more than 80 MPs. Recalling Prime Minister

Modi’s demonetisation move, the DMK leader said it was a “total failure”, and the Government could not get any black money out of it. “Likewise, the delimitation process will also be a failure”, he said, adding, “it will vanish the southern States, and will create issues between north and south”.

BJP has turned *nari* into *nara* :Akhilesh Yadav

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday accused the BJP-led Central Government of turning ‘nari’ (women) into a “nara” (slogan) for political benefits and demanded reservation for OBC and Muslim women under the proposed women’s quota law.

Participating in a debate on three bills introduced in the Lok Sabha to amend the Women’s Reservation Act, 2023, and set up a delimitation commission, Yadav said the Samajwadi Party has always supported reservation for women and furthered the cause of women-led development. All socialist leaders have believed in gender and social justice, he said. The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister sought to corner the ruling party on the women’s reservation issue, saying the BJP and its allies have Governments in 21 States and Union territories, but they

Harivansh likely to be elected Rajya Sabha deputy chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nominated member Harivansh is likely to be elected Rajya Sabha deputy chairman as five notices have been received in his favour, and the Opposition has not given any notice proposing its candidate. The election for the post of deputy chairman will take place at 11 am on Friday.

The Office of the Deputy Chairman, Rajya Sabha, had fallen vacant after the term of Harivansh ended on April 9, and Chairman CP Radhakrishnan has, under Rule 7 of the Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in the Council of States (Rajya Sabha), fixed Friday as the date for holding the election.

The last date and time for receipt of notices of motions



for election was 12 noon on Thursday.

Sources said five notices of motions have been received in favour of Harivansh for electing him to the post, and none by the Opposition. The Opposition has decided to boycott the election as a mark of protest against the Modi Government not appointing a deputy speaker in the Lok Sabha for seven years.



Samajwadi Party MP Akhilesh Yadav speaking in the Lok Sabha during the Special session of Parliament in New Delhi on Thursday

have only one woman chief minister in Delhi.

“The Delhi chief minister is a half-chief minister. Does she have powers?” he asked.

The SP chief further said, “BJP has made ‘nari’ into a ‘nara’... How many BJP MLAs or MPs are women?”

He also alleged that by pushing for an early delimitation in the name of implementing the women’s reservation law, the Government is trying to delay the population Census, as well as the caste census.

“We are for women’s reservation, but we are against the BJP’s trickery,” Yadav said and added there may be a “conspiracy” by the Government in the name of women’s empowerment.

Yadav claimed that the proposed delimitation exercise is aimed at changing areas of Lok Sabha constituencies to benefit the BJP. He asked the Government to complete the Census process before going ahead with the delimitation exercise.

Nation Focus



WILL NOT ALLOW POLITICAL DEMONETISATION: THAROOR

Congress leader Shashi Tharoor on Thursday lashed out at the Government for linking women’s reservation with delimitation, saying the Opposition will not allow “political demonetisation.” Speaking with reporters outside the Parliament House complex, Tharoor said the Government can immediately implement women’s reservation by de-linking it with delimitation, and the Opposition would support the move. “I just want to say that we don’t have any problem with women’s reservation, they (the Government) can do it immediately, but why delimitation is being included, this is our question, because there are many issues related to delimitation, a long discussion is required, but they want to wind up in 2-3 days, this is not possible,” the MP from Thiruvananthapuram said. He said the southern states have big questions which need to be answered.



OPPOSITION TRYING TO CREATE NORTH-SOUTH DIVIDE: BANSURI

BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj on Thursday accused the Opposition leaders of attempting to divide the country into north and south for political gains ahead of the Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu, saying that such efforts would fail. Elections in Tamil Nadu are due on April 23, and the results will be announced on May 4. “There are elections in Tamil Nadu, and the leaders of that State, for their political interests, are making efforts to divide the country into north and south. But these efforts will be unsuccessful,” Swaraj said. Participating in a debate in the Lok Sabha on three bills introduced for amendments to the women’s quota law and setting up a delimitation commission, Swaraj said the women’s reservation law is the ultimate destination, while the delimitation process is the road to achieve it. Delimitation is not a BJP conspiracy but a mandatory constitutional provision needed to implement the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, the New Delhi MP said.

PM Modi, Austrian Chancellor urge peace in Ukraine, West Asia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

The world is going through a “very tense” situation impacting all nations, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday, pitching for bringing lasting peace to Ukraine and West Asia, as military conflict cannot solve any problem.

Modi made the remarks after holding wide-ranging talks with Austria’s Federal Chancellor Christian Stocker that focused on significantly ramping up bilateral ties in areas of trade, defence and infrastructure.

In their talks, Modi and Stocker extensively deliberated on the consequences of the conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine on the global economy and vowed to work jointly to mitigate them. The Austrian Chancellor landed in New Delhi on Tuesday on a four-day trip. It is Stocker’s first official trip outside Europe and the first trip by an



PM Narendra Modi and Austria’s Chancellor Christian Stocker ahead of their meeting at Hyderabad House in New Delhi on Thursday

Austrian Chancellor to India after four decades. “The entire world is going through a very serious and tense situation today. And it is affecting all of us,” Modi said in his media statement.

“In such a tense global environment, India and Austria are unanimous that military conflict cannot solve problems. Whether in Ukraine or West Asia, we support a stable, sustain-

able, and lasting peace,” he said. “We also agree that reform of global institutions is essential to address growing global challenges. And eradicating terrorism is our shared commitment,” Modi noted.

Following the Modi-Stocker talks, the two sides signed six agreements, including one on setting up a fast-track mechanism to help Indian and Austrian

companies wanting to invest in each other’s economies. Another pact was signed on cooperation on military matters.

The letter of intent (LoI) on military cooperation will provide an institutional framework for promoting cooperation, building on the momentum of the India-EU defence and security partnership signed in January.

India and Austria also signed a LoI to advance counter terrorism cooperation, including to facilitate establishing a joint working group on counter terrorism.

In his remarks, Stocker said the India-Australia bilateral trade has been growing “very positively” and noted that the India-EU free trade pact will further enhance the economic engagement between the two sides.

The Austrian Chancellor, referring to the West Asia crisis, said “stability, trust, and reliable” partnerships are crucial to navigate the challenging time.

Uddhav demands women’s quota law, halt on delimitation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Thursday demanded that the Centre immediately implement the 2023 Act that gives 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies, and also put on hold the process of delimitation of constituencies.

In a brief statement in Mumbai, the former Maharashtra CM said delimitation, or redrawing, of constituencies is not about any one party’s political future, but it is an exercise about the nation’s future.

“Immediately implement the 2023 Act passed by Parliament that gives 33 per cent reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies,” Thackeray said.

Delimitation must be put on hold for now as it is an issue of national importance



and needs more discussion, the Opposition politician stated. Thackeray’s statement came on a day when Parliament began a three-day special sitting to debate three bills moved to amend the ‘Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam’, commonly known as the Women Reservation Act 2023, for its implementation in 2029, and set up a delimitation commission. Thackeray had also participated in the Opposition meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday through video conferencing.

ISRO report: 1.5 lakh space collision alerts recorded in 2025

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Space, the last frontier, is witnessing dense traffic, as evident with more than 1.5 lakh alerts last year to avoid collisions among spacecraft, according to the Indian Space Situational Assessment Report 2025 made public on Thursday. The sheer number of alerts issued indicates the growing number of human-made objects in space.

In its report, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) said the alerts came from the Combined Space Operations Centre (CSpOC) of USSPACECOM. The scale of these warnings reflects a broader shift in space activity.

According to the analysis, 328 launch attempts took place globally in 2025 alone - the highest number of launches since the beginning of the space age - of which 315 launches successfully placed

4,198 known operational satellites. “A total of 4,651 objects were added to the space object population in this year (2025), in a significant rise compared to the previous years — the space object population increased by 2,963 objects from 254 launches in 2024 and 3,135 objects from 212 launches in 2023,” the report said.

Among the objects that re-entered in 2025, 1002 objects were known spacecraft, 657 were debris objects, 108 were rocket bodies, and 144 were of unknown nature.

Meanwhile, last year, 144 Indian spacecraft were launched, including those from private operators and academic institutions.

The year 2025 saw record launches globally, but the full report now shows the operational strain behind those numbers: about 1.5 lakh close approach alerts were recorded overall, signalling how fre-



quently satellites now risk potential collisions.

This congestion is being driven largely by the rapid expansion of satellite constellations. On several occasions throughout the year, single-day launches added more than 100 objects into orbit, often through rideshare missions or overlapping deployments by competing constellations.

Such clustering has made coordination more complex, with shorter warning times and limited tracking data in

some cases. There were four collision avoidance manoeuvres (CAM) for GEO, while 14 CAMs, including one for NISAR, which is designated as Risk Mitigation Manoeuvre in NASA terminology, were performed for LEO satellites.

“Wherever feasible, collision avoidance requirements were met by adjusting orbit maintenance manoeuvres to avoid exclusive CAMs,” the report said.

Indian missions carried out 18 collision avoidance manoeuvres (CAMs) during

the year, including 14 in low Earth orbit and four in geosynchronous orbit.

“The number of operational satellites owned by the Government of India was 22 in LEO and 31 in GEO. NVS-02 continued to operate in an elliptic Geosynchronous Transfer Orbit (GTO),” according to the analysis.

India’s own space activity remained steady, with five launches from Sriharikota, one of which did not achieve its intended orbit. Eight Indian satellites were eventually placed in orbit through a mix of domestic and foreign launches.

The report said that there were five launches from Sriharikota spaceport, namely GSVL-F15/NVS-02, PSLV-C61/EOS-9, GSVL-F16/NISAR, LVM3-M5/CMS-03, and LVM3-M6/Blue bird Block-2 mission. All of them, except PSLV-C61, successfully injected the payloads in their nominally designated orbits. PSLV-C61 suffered a third-stage anomaly that resulted in a suborbital flight and could not inject the EOS-9 satellite into its orbit.

GSVL-F15 marked the 100th launch of an Indian Launch Vehicle from SDSC-SHAR. NVS-02 satellite launched by GSVL-F15 could not be raised to its designated orbit despite precise injection into GTO due to propulsion system failure. NISAR, a joint NASA-ISRO mission, was successfully launched on July 30, 2025.

CMS-03/GSAT-7R was successfully launched and placed in its designated longitude slot. Consequently, a total of 2 Indian satellites, 1 foreign satellite, and 4 rocket bodies were placed in their intended orbits by Indian launchers. In addition, three Firefly satellites, NILA, and LEAP-1 were also launched from the US. As a result, a total of 8 Indian satellites were placed in orbit.

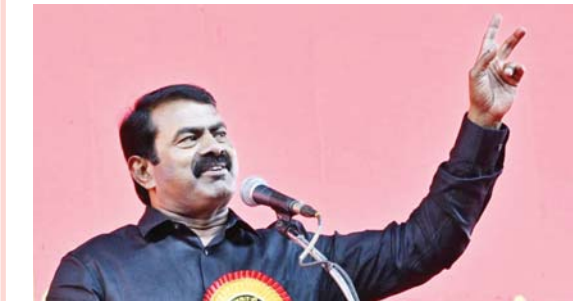


■ States Focus ■



PM MODI TAKES DIG AT DMK ON WOMEN QUOTA LAW

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday took a swipe at DMK members in the Lok Sabha for wearing black clothes to protest the women's quota law amendment bill, saying it works as a '*kala tika*' to ward off evil eye. Intervening in a debate on the three bills which seek to implement the women's reservation law of 2023 ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, the prime minister referred to black clothes and flags, and said there is a tradition to apply '*kala tika*' before commencing a good work for which he thanks them. While the DMK members wore black clothes in the House, party leader and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin hoisted a black flag in the State and burnt a copy of the delimitation bill, dubbing it a "black law" that seeks to make the Tamil people "refugees" in their own land.



NTK CHIEF SEEMAN CRITICISES DMK, AIADMK OVER FREEBIE

NTK chief Seeman on Thursday charged both the ruling DMK and AIADMK for providing freebies instead of improving the health and education sectors in the State. He assured that if his party comes to power after the April 23 polls, he would upgrade all Government hospitals, provide better education, proper drinking water and ensure the welfare of the farmers, besides solving the unemployment issue. "Freebie culture should have been stopped. They (Dravidian parties) should have concentrated on improving the standards of the people," Seeman said during a poll rally. Alleging that the DMK and AIADMK were ruling the State for several decades by wooing people through freebies and various financial assistance schemes, Seeman asked, "From where do they get money, and the State debt has crossed ₹10 lakh crore."

KPCC chief Sunny Joseph urges restraint on Kerala CM candidate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) chief Sunny Joseph on Thursday said that the party leaders and workers should exercise restraint on the issue of who should be the CM candidate of the Congress, as the high command will decide it after the Kerala Assembly poll results come on May 4.

Similar views were expressed by senior Congress leaders Ramesh Chennithala, Benny Behanan and K Muraleedharan, who said that it was inappropriate for party leaders to make comments or social media posts supporting anyone as a Chief Ministerial candidate at this stage. Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) chief Joseph told a TV channel that senior party leaders should set the example by showing restraint and not openly announcing their views on who should be the chief minister if the UDF wins.

"I am not against anyone expressing their views on the



KPCC chief Sunny Joseph

issue, but they should do it among themselves and discreetly and not openly," he said in response to some party leaders, including former KPCC president K Sudhakaran, making statements favouring Congress general secretary KC Venugopal as CM candidate. He said that such public expression of their views would create discontent among the people who express unity in the Congress. "Now is not the apt time to make such views public. My humble request to everyone in the party is to remain silent and be patient till the results come and the high command takes a decision," he emphasised. During and after the

Mamata welcomes infiltrators in West Bengal, says Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kalchini/Cooch Behar (WB)

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday asserted that while BJP Governments in his State and Tripura do not allow infiltration from Bangladesh, TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee "welcomes" illegal immigrants in Bengal.

Addressing an election rally in support of BJP candidates here at Alipurduar district bordering Assam, Sarma also claimed that the TMC Government does not allow fencing on the India-Bangladesh border in West Bengal. "In Assam and Tripura, BJP Governments do not allow infiltration from Bangladesh, but (CM) Mamata Banerjee welcomes illegal immigrants in Bengal," he alleged. Sarma said a demographic change was underway in West Bengal owing to illegal immigration, and claimed that the population of Hindus is declining in the



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma waves to the gathering during a public rally ahead of the West Bengal Assembly election, in Cooch Behar district on Thursday

State, while that of Bangladeshi Muslims is increasing. The Assam CM also asserted that the BJP will "surely win" in the north-eastern State, and "score a century" in the 126-member Assembly when the poll results are out. Assembly elections in Assam were held in a single phase on April 9, and the counting of votes will

take place on May 4.

He claimed that the Bangladeshi Muslim population increased in Assam during the previous Congress dispensation, but the scenario changed after the BJP-led Government came to power in the State.

Sarma also accused the Mamata Banerjee Government of colluding

with tea garden owners to reject an increase in daily wages of workers in Bengal and Assam.

"When she did not announce any increase in the daily wages, we unilaterally hiked the daily wages of tea garden workers in Assam from ₹240 to ₹280 along with ration," he said.

Speaking at this tea garden town in the Dooars region of north Bengal, Sarma said he promised these workers in Assam that the next BJP Government will increase their daily wages to ₹450-₹500. He said tea garden workers in Assam have been given land rights, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi has promised ₹1.60 lakh each for the construction of houses, while Banerjee "has not done anything for their welfare".

"How can tea garden workers eat fish or meat with a daily wage of only ₹240 Mamata ji, raise their wages so that they can also eat such food," Sarma said.

TMC rule has pushed Bengal into identity crisis: Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Rampurhat/Barabani (WB)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday mounted a sharp attack on the ruling TMC during a series of rallies in West Bengal, alleging that the State had been pushed into an "identity crisis" over the past 15 years because of corruption, extortion and the rise of what he described as "mafia rule".

Addressing election meetings in Birbhum's Rampurhat and Bolpur and Paschim Bardhaman's Barabani in support of BJP candidates, the BJP leader claimed that Bengal, once regarded as the country's cultural Capital, had been



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath addressing a public meeting ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections at Bolpur in Birbhum district on Thursday

turned into a "crime Capital" under the TMC Government.

"The TMC has turned Bengal from the cultural Capital of India into a crime Capital. A

BJP Government will once again make Bengal the cultural Capital of the country," Adityanath said. He urged people to vote for the BJP in

the upcoming Assembly polls, saying the people of Bengal no longer needed the TMC.

"For the last 15 years, Bengal has been facing an identity crisis. Terror, extortion, corruption and mafia raj have become the State's identity under the TMC," he said.

Adityanath alleged that an atmosphere of fear had been created among common people, particularly women and the youth.

"The people are living in fear. Daughters, sisters are not safe, the youth have no future, and the mafia has flourished under political protection. BJP is committed to ending this mafia culture," he said.

BJP attacks Congress after MLA's conviction in murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday stepped up its attack on the Congress Government in Karnataka following the conviction of party MLA Vinay Kulkarni in a 2016 murder case. The BJP alleged a complete breakdown of law and order and stated that the ruling party should be renamed as one of "crime and corruption".

The party's attack came a day after a Special Court for MPs and MLAs convicted Congress MLA Vinay Kulkarni



Shehzad Poonawalla

and 16 others in the 2016 murder case of BJP leader Yogesh Goudar. BJP national spokesperson Shehzad

Poonawalla said the Congress should rename itself from INC to "CNC - crime and corruption".

"We know that Congress is the most corrupt party, but now they are also full of criminals," he said in a video post on social media. "Kulkarni is not the only leader. There have been other convictions related to corruption and cases of electoral fraud. Many Congress MLAs have indulged in such acts in Karnataka," Poonawalla alleged.

He further alleged that the State is being run by a

Government marked by "corruption and criminalism".

"If the criminals themselves are legislators and ministers, then what will happen to law and order in Karnataka? No wonder law and order is a complete casualty, and women's safety is at an all-time low," he said. Poonawalla also claimed that people in the State are suffering due to poor infrastructure and governance. "Bad roads, potholes, crumbling infrastructure and economic doldrums - all that these MLAs are

doing is crime and corruption," he alleged.

Convicting Kulkarni and others in the Goudar's murder case, the Special Court for MPs and MLAs on Wednesday held them guilty of criminal conspiracy and related offences.

Judge Santhosh Gajanan Bhat found the accused guilty of "having entered into a criminal conspiracy to commit the murder of Yogesh Goudar," and convicted them under relevant provisions of the IPC, including Section 120(B) (criminal conspiracy).

TVK chief Vijay promises ₹2,500 monthly assistance for women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

TVK chief Vijay on Thursday unveiled a sweeping manifesto for the April 23 Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu that particularly highlighted the welfare of women, promises others — ₹2,500 monthly assistance for those below 60 years and 8 gram gold for marriage.

The actor-turned-politician also assured a quality silk saree in addition to gold for indigent brides and inter-

est-free loans up to ₹5 lakh for women-run SHGs. He assured corruption-free good governance if voted to power.

The manifesto also laid importance on education. To prevent school dropouts, mothers or guardians of children studying in government and state-aided schools will receive ₹15,000 annually. Vijay promised 100 special residential schools named after iconic leader K Kamaraj and higher education loans of up to ₹20 lakh.



Actor and TVK chief Vijay during the release of the party's manifesto for the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections at a public meeting in Chennai

He also assured AI Ministry, AI University and AI City.

The manifesto places a strong emphasis on agrarian welfare, too. The TVK chief assured a full waiver of agricultural cooperative crop loans for farmers owning less than five acres of land, while those holding more than five acres will receive a 50 per cent loan waiver. Additionally, the party promised a Minimum Support Price of ₹3,500 per quintal for paddy and ₹4,500 per tonne for sugarcane.

Women voters in Murshidabad prioritise jobs, migration issue over identity politics

PRADIPTA TAPADAR
■ Lalgola (WB)

Women voters in the migrant-majority belts of Samserganj and Lalgola in West Bengal are emerging as a potentially decisive force in Murshidabad's election, with many saying that their concerns over jobs, migration and deletions from electoral rolls now matter more than the identity politics dominating the campaign.

With thousands of men from the two constituencies working in Kerala, Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and the Gulf, women are running households, dealing with banks and Government offices, and for the first time, taking political decisions of their own. The shift has acquired added significance after around 92,000 names

were deleted from the electoral rolls in Samserganj and nearly 69,000 in neighbouring Lalgola in the Special Intensive Revision exercise.

The deletions have created widespread anxiety among women, many of whom now spend their days carrying Aadhaar cards, ration cards and voter cards to booth-level offices while their husbands and sons remain away. The TMC is seeking to consolidate women and minority voters by portraying the deletions as an attempt to frighten poor Muslim families. The BJP is sharpening its campaign around infiltration and bogus names. The Congress is trying to regain ground by arguing that both parties are exploiting fear while ignoring Murshidabad's deep unemployment and migration crisis. "Every election, they



ask whether we are Hindus or Muslims. Nobody asks why my husband is washing dishes in Kerala," said Rehana Bibi of Samserganj, whose husband works in Kochi. Rehana now manages the household, the bank account into which money is sent every month, and she made repeated visits to the BLO office after hearing that

several names had disappeared from the voters' list.

"Earlier, I listened. This time I told him to first come and stand in the ration line," she said. At another village in Samserganj, 38-year-old Hasina Khatun used to follow her husband's political instructions from Mumbai, but said women now know more than men about what is happening

in their villages," Rehana said.

"Earlier, he told me to vote for this party because he earned and sent money. But when names vanish from the voter list, or rations do not come, we go and fight. Nobody asks why my son has to clean hotel rooms in Dubai," she said. Her son's name is still on the rolls. Hers has been marked for deletion. "Officials tell us to come tomorrow, bring more papers, and bring another photocopy. If my name goes, who am I then? My husband is dead. My son is away. This house survives because I survive," Khatun said. For years, women in these villages voted the way the men told them to. Earlier, the husbands returned from Kerala or Mumbai before polling day, the family voted together, and politics

remained a male affair.

Migration has slowly changed that. Men return less often. Some do not come home even during elections because the train fare is too high or the contractor refuses to let them leave. The women remain behind, and with every year spent handling money, paperwork, and Government offices, they become less willing to merely obey. At Lalgola, Shabnam Khatun said her husband, who works at a construction site in Bengaluru, called last week and told her which symbol to press.

"Earlier, I would do what he said. This time I told him that you stay in Bengaluru, and I stay here. I will vote for the one who helps me here," she said. Her anger is not ideological. It is practical. She has spent the last fortnight

making repeated trips to an office after hearing that nearly 69,000 names have been deleted from the electoral rolls in Lalgola.

Outside a booth-level office in Samserganj, there are long lines of women carrying Aadhaar cards, ration cards, photocopies and fading voter slips. Several of them said they do not fully understand the legal process. They only know that if their names disappear, something larger may vanish with it. "Before asking me for my vote, first tell me whether my name still exists," said a woman in Samserganj whose migrant husband's name remains on the list although he has been in Kerala for nine months. "My husband is not even here. Still, his name remains. I am the one standing in the

queue. Yet my name disappears. Does that mean I count for less?" she said.

Now, in these villages, women are beginning to form opinions separate from the absent men. They are also increasingly tired of identity politics. "They come and ask if we are Hindus or Muslims," said a woman in Lalgola whose two sons work in Mumbai. "Nobody asks why both my sons had to leave the village for work. Nobody asks why I borrow money every month before the remittance comes," she said. The TMC is trying to turn the deleted-names controversy into a campaign among women and minority voters.

District leader Abu Taher Khan accused the BJP and the Election Commission of India of frightening poor Muslim women. (PTI)



TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS

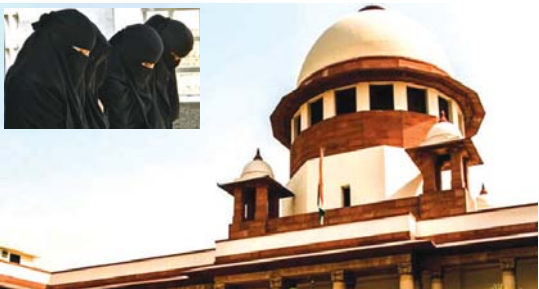
Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in



Order Order

SC notice to Centre on PIL in Muslim personal law



The Supreme Court on Thursday sought the Centre's response on a PIL challenging the constitutional validity of certain provisions of the Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act, 1937, on the ground that those are allegedly discriminatory against women.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Panchol took note of the submissions made by lawyer Prashant Bhushan, who appeared in the matter for petitioners Poulomi Pavini Shukla and the Nyaya Naari Foundation, and issued a notice to the Union Ministry of Minority Affairs.

The plea says the current Shariat inheritance rules are "manifestly discriminatory" against women, often granting them only half or less of the share allocated to their male counterparts. Bhushan said the 1937 Act violates Article 14 (right to equality) of the Constitution.

He said matters of succession are civil in nature and do not constitute an "essential religious practice" protected under Article 25. "Saying women will get half or even less than half compared to male counterparts is discriminatory," the lawyer said.

Bail denied to accused in WhatsApp trading scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has rejected the anticipatory bail plea of a man accused in a cyber fraud case involving cheating through a WhatsApp investment scheme, saying that his custodial interrogation was necessary to unearth the larger conspiracy.

Additional Sessions Judge Harvinder Singh was hearing the anticipatory plea filed by Sumit, who has been accused of "serious cyber fraud" in which the complainant was induced to part with a substantial amount of money on the pretext of investment.

In the order dated April 10, the court said, "The grant of anticipatory bail to the applicant accused would amount to shutting doors upon further investigation into the matter, upon ascertaining the role of applicant accused and upon further investigation to unearth the whole conspiracy."

The FIR against the accused was registered at the cyber police station in Shahdara under BNS Sections 318(3) (cheating) and 340 (using forged documents as genuine).

According to the prosecution, the accused allegedly lured the complainant into a WhatsApp group on the pretext of investment opportunities and induced her to transfer a substantial amount of money by promising high returns.

The fraud was allegedly carried out using a mobile number registered in the name of the accused's mother, indicating an attempt to conceal identity, and was part of a larger coordinated scheme under investigation.

The court also took note of the accused's relationship with one of the main co-accused and the investigating agency's claim that recovery of the SIM card and device used in the offence was pending.

"It is noted that this is a case of cyber fraud where the complainant was induced to join a WhatsApp group for the purpose of cheating. She was made to



part with huge sums of money on the pretext of investment.

The phone number of the mother of the applicant was actively used in WhatsApp chats, and he is related to one of the main accused in the matter," the court said.

Rejecting the defence contention that the accused had been falsely implicated and was not required for investigation, the court held that granting anticipatory bail at this stage would hamper the probe.

SC refuses plea on guidelines for display of Ashoka Chakra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a plea seeking a direction to the Centre and others to frame guidelines for the display of the Ashoka Chakra on the national flag.

A bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi told the petitioner, who appeared in person, to do something constructive for society.

"There is no need to be so emotional about these things. Your idea is good.



You have informed the authorities. Now it is for the authorities to see what they want to do," the CJI told the petitioner. "You do some constructive work for society," the bench said.

The petitioner showed a picture of the Ashoka Chakra installed at a roundabout in Varanasi, but the bench refused to entertain the plea.



Plea in SC against deceitful religious conversion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A plea was filed in the Supreme Court on Thursday in the aftermath of allegations of religious conversion and sexual harassment at a multinational company (MNC) in Nashik seeking directions to control deceitful religious conversion.

The plea was filed in the backdrop of charges of sexual harassment and allegations of forced religious conversion levelled by eight female employees at TCS' office in Nashik.

The plea filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay contended that deceitful religious conversion is not only a serious threat to sovereignty, secularism, democracy, and liberty but also a menace



to fraternity, dignity, unity and national integration.

The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey, has sought directions to the

Centre and State Government to take stringent steps to control religious conversion.

It has also sought directions to the Centre and States to

establish special courts to deal with religious conversion cases and declare that the sentence for the deceitful religious conversion shall be

consecutive, not concurrent.

The petition stated that the Right to Freedom of Religion does not carry the right to convert others through fraud, force, coercion or cheating.

Article 25 gives freedom of conscience, profession, practice and propagation of religion, subject to public order, health and morality, it said.

"All persons will have the right freely to profess, practice and propagate religion and not that all persons will have the right to freely profess, practice and propagate religion. It means the right to profess, practice and propagate religion is free to everyone, but cannot be practised absolutely or freely.

The plea said it has conditions of public order, morality and health, and the other provisions of this part. The

freedom to act upon one's religion is not absolute, it added.

"The expression does not mean that every person is free to do whatever they wish in the name of religion. Rather, it means that everyone has the right freely to profess, practise and propagate, but this freedom itself is subject to reasonable restrictions," the plea said.

The plea has been filed by Upadhyay in his pending petition seeking direction to the Centre and states to take tough steps to control fraudulent religious conversions.

Observing that religious conversion is a serious issue which should not be given a political colour, the top court in 2023 had sought the assistance of Attorney General R Venkataramani on the plea.

SC flags lack of trust between West Bengal Govt, ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Flagging the lack of trust between the West Bengal Government and the Election Commission, the Supreme Court on Thursday dismissed a plea challenging the transfer of more than 1,000 administrative and police officers by the poll panel in the election-bound state.

The apex court, however, kept open for adjudication in future the contentious legal question about whether the Election Commission of India (ECI) needed to consult the concerned state before effecting administrative changes in poll-bound states.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi also observed that it was the "misfortune" of the country that the purpose of creating the All India Services was getting frustrated. The CJI said the apex court had to appoint judicial officers in the exercise of Special Intensive



Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal as there was trust deficit between the parties.

"They have no trust in the officers of the State Government and the state has no trust in the officers brought by them (EC)," the bench observed. The top court passed the order while hearing a plea challenging a Calcutta High Court order dated March 31. The High Court had dismissed a PIL challenging the transfer of officers by the poll panel in West Bengal. Elections to the 294-member West Bengal

Assembly will be held in two phases — on April 23 and 29. Votes will be counted on May 4.

During the hearing, senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee, appearing for petitioner Arka Kumar Nag, said that for the first time, the chief secretary of a State has been transferred in such a manner.

He said around 1,100 officers in West Bengal were transferred "overnight" after the notification for the Assembly polls was issued. "This is not something that has happened for the first time or that has happened in this state only," the bench observed. Banerjee argued that the ECI needed to consult with the state before effecting such transfers.

"The officers who have been transferred or posted are all from the West Bengal cadre. It is not that officers from other states have been appointed. They are all serving officers of the state of West Bengal. Whether they occupy 'A' post or 'B' post, how does it matter?" the CJI asked.

Kejriwal urges Justice Sharma to take affidavit on record

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) chief Arvind Kejriwal urged Delhi High Court judge Swarana Kanta Sharma on Thursday to take on record his additional affidavit claiming that the judge has a "direct conflict of interest" in continuing to hear the CBI's petition against his discharge in the liquor-policy case.

Justice Sharma directed the registry to take the former chief minister's affidavit on record, while clarifying that she is not "reopening the matter" after reserving her verdict on his application seeking her recusal from hearing the case.

Kejriwal appeared before the court virtually through video-conferencing.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who represents the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), said the agency would file its written submissions. On Kejriwal's request, the court asked the federal agency to give him a copy of its submissions.

"But this matter is reserved. I am not reopening it. Reserved matters are not reopened," the judge clarified.

In his additional affidavit dated April 14, Kejriwal has claimed that the judge's children are empanelled central Government lawyers who receive work through the



solicitor general, who is appearing in the matter for the CBI.

He has said there is a "direct conflict of interest", which has "amplified" his apprehension and constituted grounds for recusal.

Kejriwal has also prayed



for time to make further oral and rejoinder submissions, fearing that continuing the case before Justice Sharma might not carry the "full appearance of judicial detachment, independence and neutrality that the law requires".

SC permits petitioner to withdraw 17 PILs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A lawyer, who was reprimanded last month for "frivolous and baseless" public interest litigations, on Thursday sought the Supreme Court's nod to withdraw 17 of the 47 separate PILs he had filed and said he would first approach concerned authorities.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Panchol permitted advocate Sachin Gupta to withdraw the pleas.

Appearing as petitioner in person, Gupta said he was withdrawing the PILs as soon as the 17 pleas came up for hearing before the bench.

"I am withdrawing the



petitions. I will approach the authorities," he said.

On April 10, when 25 separate PILs came up for hearing, the apex court told Gupta that he should approach the authorities instead of rushing to the court. The court would entertain his petitions at an appropriate stage if the need arose, the bench said.

The top court allowed him to withdraw the 25 PILs which were listed for hearing.

Before that, on March 9, the apex court trashed five "frivolous" PILs, including one seeking a scientific study on whether onion and garlic contain "tamasic" (negative) energy, and asked if he drafted them in the middle of the night.

SC refuses plea of Army veterans against current pay-fixation rules

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a plea filed by a group of ex-servicemen challenging the validity of the current pay-fixation rules, alleging that the existing framework unfairly penalises Army veterans who join civil services after their retirement.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, however, allowed lawyer Ashwini Upadhyay to make a representation in this regard to the authorities concerned which, in turn, will take a decision as early as possible.

The bench said if the petitioners, including lead petitioner Baidya Nath Choudhary, are dissatisfied, they can approach the



Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) with the grievances.

Choudhary and five others, in their plea filed through advocate-on-record Ashwani Dubey, had referred to Rule 8 of the Central Civil Services (Revised Pay) Rules, 2016, and a subsequent Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) memorandum dated May 1, 2017.

You will get objective treatment, Delhi HC to Mattoo case convict's release plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday assured Santosh Kumar Singh, life convict in the 1996 Priyadarshini Mattoo rape and murder case, that he would get an "objective treatment" on the issue of his premature release, as it remarked that the sentence review board seemed to be proceeding on public perception.

Justice Anup J Bhambhani said there was no doubt that the offence was heinous and the family of the deceased suffered a "permanent loss", but the sentence review board (SRB) seemed to be deciding the pleas for premature release like the blindfolded Lady Justice.

"SRB seems to be proceeding on public perception. You are a hugely unpopular person... SRB is looking at things like Lady Justice as she originally was, with blindfolds. Your name doesn't sound good so I am rejecting it," the judge remarked orally.

The court informed that it was seized of several other cases arising from the rejection of premature release pleas of convicts by the SRB and listed Singh's petition on the same issue along with them on April 20.

The court was dealing with Singh's application seeking to advance from

May 18 the date of hearing on his petition regarding premature release.

Senior advocate Mohit Mathur, appearing for the convict, submitted that Singh has spent 31 years in custody and, despite the High Court's exhaustive decision passed last year on an earlier rejection of his plea for premature release, the SRB rejected his case again on the same grounds.



Justice Bhambhani said that there were "worse cases", including that of 41 years in custody, as the SRB was "just rejecting things" on account of the heinousness of the offence despite receiving recommendations to the contrary.

"You will be treated objectively. You will be treated in accordance with what I distil," he said.

In his petition, Singh challenged the November 27, 2025, decision of the SRB rejecting his case for premature release.

The counsel for Mattoo's brother opposed the plea to advance the date of hearing and said the convict committed a grave offence.

PIL against sale of liquor in tetra packs in UP



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a PIL seeking a ban on sale of liquor in tetra packs in Uttar Pradesh and asked the petitioner to move the State authorities with the grievances.

Uttar Pradesh recently approved the new excise policy with several key changes, including the introduction of an e-lottery system for allocation of liquor and 'bhang' (cannabis) shops.

It also announced that country liquor, previously sold in glass bottles, will now be mandatorily packaged in tetra packs to enhance safety and prevent adulteration.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi was urged by lawyer Ashok Pande, appearing for PIL petitioner Meenakshi Shree Tiwari, that the sale of liquor in tetra packs be banned in the State.

He said such tetra packs are easily reaching educational institutions in the State and spoiling the atmosphere there.



Editor's
TAKE

Delimitation & women's quota: A paradigm shift

As seat redistribution shifts power to northern States and women's quotas hinge on boundary changes, the reform push will reshape representation and the federal balance

Indian parliament, as it has been since independence, is about to change radically. Presently, it has 545 Lok Sabha seats and reservation of seats for the Scheduled Castes and schedule tribes. The proposed bills being tabled in parliament will not only change the number of seats in Lok Sabha but will also give women 33 per cent reservation, a long-standing demand to bring about gender parity in governance.

As the Union government's move to introduce three Bills on delimitation and women's reservation, there is considerable resistance from the Opposition and regional parties from the South, that feel that it would shift the political fulcrum in the North and penalise the southern states for effectively controlling their population. These bills will once and for all change the balance of political power across regions and genders. The proposed expansion of the Lok Sabha from 545 to 850 seats under the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill will be based on the population, and densely populated states of the North will see a definite surge in their seat allocation. The allocation of seats to States will now be based on population figures drawn from the 2011 Census for the upcoming delimitation exercise.

This puts an end to the long-standing freeze on seat reallocation which was done to incentivise and reward States that successfully controlled population growth. The implications are immediate and far-reaching. States such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Rajasthan – where population growth has been higher – will have higher parliamentary representation.

Conversely, southern States like Tamil Nadu and Kerala, which have achieved demographic stabilisation will have lesser representation. Experts believe that representation in Parliament must be a reflection of historical, cultural, and developmental diversity and should be evenly spread.

Yet another aspect of the proposed bill – the women's representation will be deferred until after delimitation is completed, and has been given a 15-year window. By tethering women's reservation to a potentially contentious delimitation exercise, the government risks delaying a reform whose time has arguably long been overdue. Critics argue that if the seats can be increased based on the 2011 census, why cannot the women's representation be based on the same census?

The opposition's reservations are therefore twofold. First, there is a substantive concern over federal imbalance. Second, there is a procedural unease. The haste with which these Bills are being pushed raises questions about the adequacy of consultation. Championing women's reservation allows the ruling party to claim the credit for gender reform, but in practice, it is just deferring it for another 15 years.

A process seen as unilateral, risks eroding legitimacy, even if the outcomes are defensible. Ultimately, delimitation and women's reservation are the basis of the idea of representation itself. The challenge before the government is not just to legislate change, but to incorporate suggestions from all quarters to make it inclusive and truly representational.

Super El Niño: A brewing climate shock

There is a high probability of El Niño forming later this year. With global temperatures already near record highs, this evolving pattern could disrupt monsoons, strain agriculture, and trigger extreme weather worldwide—placing economies on edge.



BK
SINGH

National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) on April 9, has predicted that there is 61% chance that El Nino will be formed in late summer and fall towards the end of this year and there is 33% chance that it would be a strong one, typically known as "Super El Nino". There have been only 5 such El Nino have been registered since 1950 and the last one was formed in 2015-16. The Copernicus Climate Change Service has also confirmed that 2026 March has registered second highest Sea Surface temperature, which points towards the possibility of El Nino conditions forming later inn summer this year.

April 9, advisory of NOAA has confirmed that an eventful La Nina winter, when powerful storms have disrupted the lives of the people on American and European continents, is concluded and Pacific Ocean has shifted into a neutral pattern such that Sea surface temperature in central and east-central tropical Pacific has become average.

La Nina, neutral and El Nino are three phases of El-Nino southern oscillation (ENSO) cycle formed on account of natural changes in Pacific Ocean temperature and atmospheric circulation. El Nino typically means less activity in Atlantic basin and more activity in central and eastern equatorial Pacific. During El Nino cycle more tropical cyclones is experienced in Pacific and lower than the average in Atlantic. A super El Nino acts as a shield bringing higher pressure and vertical wind shear that suppresses hurricane formation in Atlantic. The weather pattern in this cycle in the equatorial Pacific region experiences droughts, floods, extreme heat, hurricanes and declining Sea ice. The sea surface temperature rises by more than 2 degrees Celsius, resulting in hotter than average summer in Western United States, parts of Africa, Europe and India. Further, the tropical countries like Caribbean islands and Indonesia may experience severe drought and extreme heat.

The atmosphere is likely to trap more greenhouse gases and increase the concentration of carbon dioxide and 2027 is set to register record rise in average global temperature. So far 2024 has been the warmest, and now 2027 is likely to breach this. The experts have also forecasted that the super El Nino of 2026-27 is likely to disperse more heat than what three earlier super El Nino events in 1982-83, 1997-98 and 2015-16 have dispersed. The unusual heat and humidity may intensify the flow of atmospheric moisture. As the warmer atmosphere has huge amount of moisture carrying capacity, it will bring excessive rains and flash floods in the



EL NINO
EVENTS ARE
ASSOCIATED
WITH RAINFALL
DEFICIT IN
CENTRAL
AMERICA,
WHICH MAY
DIRECTLY
IMPACT WATER
LEVELS IN
GATUN LAKE -
A FRESH
WATER
RESERVOIR
THAT POWERS
THE LOCK
SYSTEM OF
PANAMA
CANAL

B K Singh ex Head of
Forest Force, Kamataka
and teach "Economics" in
Karnataka Forest
Academy

@dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

The Pioneer

Some urban and rural areas may encounter drinking water problem, which has to be managed by agencies judiciously. A cap on the rent of the water tankers may be imposed to ensure that water-tanker mafias are not allowed to take advantage of the situation and the population is not put further into the hardships.

The rising temperature of the planet can lead to devastating wildfire in different regions. While the burning of forests of California, Boreal and Amazon forests can damage the global lung spaces by reducing the capacity of Carbon dioxide sequestration, the continued fire can disrupt the lives and livelihood of the communities' dependent on forest resources.

Strait of Hormuz is already a choke point, where 20% of oil and gas from GCC countries flows to the world market. A sizable proportion of fertilizer and helium also flow through this point. Many economies have taken a hit owing to the trade disruption at the strait. El Nino is predicted to create another choke point at Panama Canal.

El Nino events are associated with rainfall deficit in Central America, which may directly impact water levels in Gatun lake - a fresh water reservoir that powers the lock system of Panama Canal. During El Nino driven drought experienced in 2023-24, the transit of ships through it was slashed down to 24 vessels per day. It also faced a shipping draft restriction of 44 feet, permitting vessels navigating shallower ports. These vessels transported reduced cargo due to fallen water level in Gatun lake.

The prolonged disruption had ripple effect in global supply chains, driving congestion, higher transit cost and several re-routing of the cargo vessels. However, a shift to La Nina and a sustained rainfall restored water level in Gatun reservoir and the Canal could transport nearly 36 vessels with full 50 feet draft. NOAA has forecasted that 2026-27 El Nino could again reduce water level in Gatun reservoir and bring down the daily transit slots as well as the cargo loads.

Once the number of vessels are restricted, the powerful countries defy the order and attempt to control the canal. Trump in his second term has already expressed once to take over Panama Canal. This was to counter China - the country which booked maximum number of slots for its vessels to transport cargo during the water stress period in 2023-24. The catchments for Gatun lake spreads over 2313 sq km and is fed by Chagres, Trinidad, Ciri Grande Rivers. Since US is a dominant force in the region, it must add Indio River to water supply system to counteract low water levels during drought. World leaders should also protect the tropical rain forests included in Soberania National Park, Barro Colorado Island and Chagres National Park. If these forests are continued to be plundered by local communities for expanding agriculture and beef production, El Nino can disrupt the global trade and damage the economy considerably.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The luxury of going somewhere



RACHNA
LAKHPATRI

2ND OPINION

There was a time when travel was an act of spontaneity. You had a week off, a cousin's wedding in another city, or simply a restlessness that needed geography to cure it—and you booked a ticket. Not a spreadsheet. Not a three-hour comparison exercise across six tabs. Just a ticket.

That time feels almost quaint now.

Somewhere between a relentless climb in aviation fuel costs, dynamic pricing algorithms that seem personally offended by your desire to fly on a Friday, and toll rates that treat every highway like a private members' club, the simple act of getting from one place to another has quietly transformed into a financial negotiation. Travel — for work, for leisure, for a

medical appointment in a city with a better hospital — has started to resemble a luxury. Not by aspiration. By arithmetic. This shift is something both practical and deeply human unfolding in response. People have started hunting. Not for experiences — for deals. The same energy that once drove us to circle supermarket shelves on a Saturday morning, trolley tilted, eyes scanning for the yellow discount sticker, has migrated entirely to travel. We are bargain-hunting our way across the world now, and the supermarket has simply gone digital.

The tools of this new hunt are, predictably, AI and the resurgent travel expert. It is a fascinating pairing — the algorithmic and the instinctive, working in parallel for the same harried traveller trying to fly to Mumbai without being quietly robbed. AI-powered platforms now scrape thousands of fares in seconds, flagging the precise Tuesday morning window in which a ticket to Bangalore is somehow forty percent cheaper than Thursday evening.

Meanwhile, the human travel consultant — long declared extinct by the rise of booking apps — has made a quiet, confident comeback. Because it turns out, when the pricing systems become complex enough, people stop trusting machines and reach,

instinctively, for another person.

What this signals is not merely economic stress. It is a fundamental reclassification of movement itself.

For centuries, the ability to travel freely was a marker of freedom.

Of citizenship. Of a life that had options. When a family starts reconsidering a holiday because fuel surcharges have inflated the cab fare to the airport, or when a daily-wage worker calculates whether the train to the next city for a job interview is worth the cost of the ticket — travel stops being a choice and starts being a privilege. And privilege, by definition, is unequally distributed.

The middle class, once again, finds itself in the uncomfortable middle — too mobile to stay put, too financially squeezed to move freely. Scouring

the internet at midnight for a flash sale fare. Downloading one more app. Asking AI what the best day to book is.

There is something quietly heartbreaking about that image. We were promised a connected world. Nobody mentioned it would cost this much to actually cross it.

The writer is a freelancer writes on development and social issues

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Regulating Khap panchayats

The Rajasthan High Court has rightly declared the diktats, social boycotts, and penalties imposed by khap panchayats unconstitutional, directing the state to frame a policy to curb such practices. These extra-judicial bodies often function without legal authority, issuing harsh punishments that violate fundamental rights, particularly in matters of marriage and personal choice. The court has recommended the creation of a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) and the appointment of nodal officers to address such illegal actions.

These measures are essential, as khap decisions frequently undermine constitutional guarantees of equality, liberty, and dignity. The Supreme Court of India has also consistently held that community approval cannot override the choices of consenting adults. At the same time, completely dismantling khap panchayats may not be practical. In many rural areas, they derive legitimacy from deep-rooted social networks and occasionally contribute to social reform. Therefore, a balanced approach is needed—one that firmly curbs coercive and unconstitutional practices while encouraging progressive change from within. Judicial intervention is essential, but long-term reform must combine accountability with community engagement to ensure sustainable social transformation.

YASHPAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Rethink women's reservation

The article "Delimitation: A Constitutional Necessity" by Tuhin A Sinha presents a strong defence of the government's decision to link women's reservation to delimitation. It argues that the move is constitutionally grounded in Articles 82 and 170 and reflects decisive governance. Critics such as Sonia Gandhi are portrayed as overly focused on procedural concerns. However, this framing overlooks several critical issues. Linking the long-pending 33 per cent reservation for women to post-2026 delimitation effectively delays its implementation, given uncertainties surrounding the next census.

The claim of decisiveness appears overstated, as the legislation remains contingent on future developments. Concerns from southern states about losing parliamentary representation due to population-based delimitation are also downplayed. These fears highlight the need for broader federal consensus. Additionally, delays in conducting the census further postpone meaningful reform, raising questions about intent versus execution. The debate should not be reduced to political rhetoric contrasting "willpower" with past inaction. Instead, a more balanced approach is required—one that delinks women's reservation from delimitation and ensures timely implementation without compromising federal equity or democratic trust.

SK PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

Voices that defined an era

The Mangeshkar sisters—Lata, Asha, Usha, and Meena—stand as towering figures in Indian music, each leaving a distinct and lasting legacy. At the forefront was Lata Mangeshkar, revered as the "Nightingale of India," whose career spanned decades and over 30,000 songs. Her renditions of classics like "Ae Mere Watan Ke Logon" in 1963, which moved Jawaharlal Nehru to tears, and "Lag Jaa Gale" set unmatched emotional standards. She was honoured with the Bharat Ratna in 2001.

Her sister Asha Bhosle brought unmatched versatility, excelling in everything from cabaret hits like "Piya Tu Ab To Aaja" to classical masterpieces like "Dil Cheez Kya Hai," earning a National Award and global recognition with over 11,000 recordings. Usha Mangeshkar carved her niche with devotional and folk-inspired songs, notably "Mungda" and the bhajans of Jai Santoshi Ma.

Meanwhile, Meena Khadikar nurtured non-film and children's music traditions. Together, their collaborations and shared moments—whether on stage or at home—created a musical legacy unmatched in Indian history, echoing harmony, individuality, and enduring artistry.

CK SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

PIC TALK



A farmer shows a snake shaped cucumber from a field, near the Taj Mahal, in Agra, Uttar Pradesh

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



facebook.com/dailypioneer



@TheDailyPioneer



instagram.com/dailypioneer



linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

TAMIL NADU'S DEFIANCE OVER DELIMITATION

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. K. Stalin has intensified his opposition to the Union government's proposed delimitation exercise, issuing what he described as a "final warning." During a protest in Namakkal on April 16, he publicly burned a copy of the draft Delimitation Bill and hoisted a black flag. Similar demonstrations were organised across the state, including outside his residence in Chennai, symbolising strong resistance to what he termed a "black law."

These protests coincide with a special session of Parliament, where key measures, including the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill and the Delimitation Bill, are expected to be introduced. The proposals aim to redraw parliamentary constituencies and enable 33 per

cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha.

Stalin has raised concerns that delimitation based on population could penalise southern states like Tamil Nadu, which have successfully implemented population control measures. He alleges that the exercise disproportionately favours northern states and lacks adequate consultation with state governments.

Warning of widespread resistance, Stalin emphasised that any move undermining Tamil Nadu's representation would provoke a strong political response. With Parliament's strength potentially rising to around 850 seats, concerns over equitable representation remain central to the debate.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Preventive wars are a product of sick minds

The most subtle and sensitive human instinct is the preservation of their progeny, and to ensure a better tomorrow for them. Why is this basic truth ignored? Decisions with far-reaching consequences come from leaders occupying top-level positions



Wars, violence, fundamentalism, terrorism, climate change, water and air pollution—these threats to human existence on the planet Earth are obviously the consequence of what transpires in the minds of human beings. Decisions are made by the chosen representatives of the people, the leaders. At this stage of human history, nations are organically interconnected, and everyone, particularly the leaders, comprehends this reality. So why does the world inflict so much violence, hatred, destruction, and damage on itself?

The most subtle and sensitive human instinct is the preservation of their progeny, and to ensure a better tomorrow for them. Why is this basic truth ignored? Decisions with far-reaching consequences come from leaders occupying top-level positions. Something must be seriously missing in the civilisational advancements and progress of the human race. Power, it is universally acknowledged, corrupts. It often blinds some beyond repair. Does it offer any clue?

Clarity of objectives, coupled with compassion for all, forms the foundation of genuine leadership. This requires consistency, commitment, dexterity, and skill in envisioning goals, implementing them, and consistently evaluating the extent of the human good achieved. After WWII, people and nations realised that wars offer no pathways to peace. The associated human and material destruction impedes the civilisational march. Every initiative that attempts to give a dignified and humane life to every individual could be launched only when peace prevails, and a conducive environment offers undisturbed interactive opportunities, right from families to communities and nations. Every dignified interaction invariably brings forth positivity. Very often, it is the hegemonistic traits of human personality that overshadow facts and blur the impending negative consequences. Donald Trump, in fact, followed the footsteps of his predecessors who had contributed to the destruction of Vietnam, Libya, Iraq, and Afghanistan. In most of the cases where the US intervened militarily, it had to beat an



WARS, VIOLENCE, FUNDAMENTALISM, TERRORISM, CLIMATE CHANGE, WATER AND AIR POLLUTION—THESE THREATS TO HUMAN EXISTENCE ON THE PLANET EARTH ARE OBVIOUSLY THE CONSEQUENCE OF WHAT TRANSPIRES IN THE MINDS OF HUMAN BEINGS

The author is an educationist, a Padma Shri awardee, and works in religious amity and social cohesion

 dailypioneer
 @jagmohansrajput
 The Pioneer

embarrassing retreat. Experts are convinced; the US is destined to meet the same fate in Iran!

It was in the second half of the 18th century when the well-known illustrious inventor Benjamin Franklin, in a very subtle and decent manner, stated: “I hope that mankind will at length, as they call themselves reasonable creatures, have reason and sense enough to settle their differences without cutting throats; for in my opinion there never was a good war, or a bad peace.” Franklin possessed not only an analytical mind augmented with a clear scientific temper but was also blessed with empathy and compassion. Amongst several of his inventions, the ‘lightning conductor’ must have saved numerous lives over the centuries and prevented destruction of human creations. He was also the President of the State of Pennsylvania. Maybe the successive US presidents after WWII never had the time and inclination to ponder over alternative strategies to ‘cutting throats’! Donald Trump, at the beginning of the second quarter of the 21st century, has not only unleashed war machinery against Iran but also unhesitatingly threatened to erase an entire civilisation from the surface of the earth! He went ahead further: he could do it in one night!

Expectedly, he backed out. For peace negotiations, Trump had to rely on the host of Osama bin Laden. No other nations worth the name were ready to stand with the USA, which failed miserably in assessing the strength and morale of Iran before he launched his ill-fated misadventure as President. Has Donald Trump redefined the contours of political and democratic leadership? He has very clearly indicated how he would like to be eulogised by the people and remembered in history as a great peacemaker! He tried his best to fetch the Nobel Prize for Peace, enthusiastically proposed by another known peacemaker nation of present times, Pakistan. If one goes by the logic of the incumbent US President, Pakistan is going great guns to create global peace. Having placed himself in a very embarrassing situation, with no nations coming to join hands with him in the war, the only nation he could find dependable to create a face-saving pull-out situation was Pakistan!

Trump, probably not the United States, stands fully convinced of the doctrine that preventive war is the sole guarantee of creating a world of peace! His predecessors have adhered to it in several

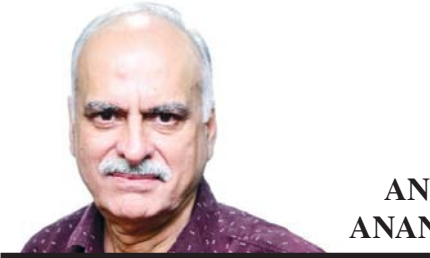
cases, of course unsuccessfully each time! The manner the US ran away from Afghanistan, leaving all of its armoury to be used by the warlords, who had earlier established their might as the nemesis of the American forces. Preventive wars are the brainchild of sick minds that are overpowered by hegemonistic traits in the belief that they, their race, and nation are different, distinct, and superior to every other human being around them! Dwight D. Eisenhower, who was the Supreme Commander of the Allied forces and became the President of the United States (1953-61), had very clearly indicated that the idea of preventive war was that of Hitler, and that he would not even listen to anyone seriously who came and talked of preventive wars. Trump has launched the present preventive war to bar Iran from producing nuclear weapons that could become a great danger to peace and security of the US! This brings forth another aspect that relates organically to the human capabilities of critical thinking, readiness to take a broader and comprehensive view of happenings around, envisioning the future, and never forgetting the interdependence of

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

humanity. Universalisation of elementary education and access to higher education on a broader basis were considered to be a great support to every human being in a world of peace, fraternity, and equality in democracies. This assumption dominated education policy formulations in countries that are still struggling to enhance their literacy rates and educational opportunities for their young people. The estimated literacy rates in Germany, Great Britain, and the United States were above 90 per cent even at the beginning of WWI, and obviously rose higher at the beginning of WWII. Why have the expansion of education and the great rise in literacy rates not created defence of peace amongst the literate and educated? To comprehend the anomaly, one would be greatly benefited by the wisdom of the great pacifist, Albert Einstein: “Our schoolbooks glorify war and conceal its horrors. They indoctrinate children with hatred. I would teach peace rather than war, love rather than hate.” He was convinced all along that it stood in the way of human progress.

Around the mid-half of the 20th century, democracy dawned upon numerous newly liberated countries and generated high hopes for the emergence of a world that would offer liberty, equality, and fraternity to one and all! Power would no longer remain the monopoly of dynastic and despotic leadership. One could say without any hesitation that it has not worked. The creation of the United Nations Organization (now UN) and its constituent bodies like the UNSC, UNHRC, and UNESCO were expected to expedite the transition to a world that would offer equality, particularly to those discarded and humiliated socially, culturally, and economically anywhere on the globe. In their enthusiasm, nations missed one point: the imperialists had accepted their ouster to their homes only with grave anguish in their hearts. Their skills in machinations and manipulation had not deserted them. They initially created the veto power for four of themselves. When Trump attacks Iran, it is time to examine things on a much wider horizon: why is it so tough for the privileged ones to internalise and accept the basics of the ‘equality of all human beings’? This is the bigger issue before humanity than resolving the US-Israel-Iran war.

The shift from Chief Minister to Rajya Sabha: Examining the political exit of Nitish Kumar



Inglorious end to a glorious political chapter! It is not to undermine political and administrative achievements, despite his penchant for shifting political loyalties like quicksand, of the longest-serving Chief Minister of Bihar, Nitish Kumar. It reflects a gory but interesting political chapter in the history of Bihar, perhaps the worst kind of broad daylight political manoeuvre accomplished with the active participation of the one against whom it was plotted.

Not only did he become part of the political machination, willingly or unwillingly (only time will tell), but he also tried to rewrite certain rules in the political realm. It went a step ahead of overnight changing alliances, offering strange and sometimes flimsy reasoning and thereby basing everything on “welfare of Bihar”.

Well, Nitish babu has, at last, become an honourable member of the Upper House of Parliament, popularly known as Rajya Sabha, as a barter to have vacated the Chief Minister’s chair in one of the most politically significant and historic states of Bihar. If the reports quoting him are to be believed, becoming a Rajya Sabha MP was his cherished desire in the twilight of his political career, for which he did not mind leaving the chief ministership. It has come as an utter surprise even to his close aides, barring those who are alleged to have plotted his migration from Patna to New Delhi in connivance with the powers that be at the Centre.

At the centre of this political episode of sordid dimensions is a new manifestation of BJP’s now popular operation “Lotus”, which is squarely aimed at expanding the party’s footprint through wresting power, electorally or otherwise. The so-far elusive BJP-led government in Bihar has, at last, been achieved through securing Kumar’s “help”.

It is both a matter of concern and of in-depth investigation as to how the present state arose. How did an astute, able, and honest political leader such as Kumar fall into the trap of “Operation Lotus” in his new form? After all, the socialist in him has been a BJP ally for decades now and can be accused, alongside his other ideological colleagues like former Defence Minister, George Fernandes, of helping in the growth of the saffron party.



In this backdrop, he deserved better treatment than being dispatched to the Rajya Sabha in lieu of offering the chief ministership to the ally partner on a platter.

It would not have been possible for the BJP to reach the present state without the help and assistance of Kumar, whatever the reasons might be. In order to checkmate his more wily socialist friends, Lalu Prasad Yadav and late Ram Vilas Paswan, though the latter also joined the saffron camp after some time, the newly sworn Rajya Sabha member saw no option but to make common cause with the BJP, which in the end has proved to be his nemesis.

To be fair to Kumar, but for a very brief interregnum when he joined the Congress-led I.N.D.I.A. combine against the Narendra

Modi dispensation, he remained steadfast in his anti-Congressism, though at the cost of cherished secular values. On the other hand, Paswan reaped political dividends both in Congress- and BJP-headed formations, which is still bearing fruit for his next generation.

Kumar’s impeccably clean image had stood him in good stead throughout his political career, and he was able to make his mark whether as Chief Minister or a Union Minister, which earned him the sobriquet of “Susashan Babu”. But in the end, the vagaries of practical and manipulative politics seemed to have got the better of his value-based political anchor.

Despite being the sheet anchor and author of Janata Dal (United), Kumar had been gradually losing control under all-round pressure exerted by the powerful alliance partner BJP, with the active assistance of some of his own party persons. By the time he took oath as a Rajya Sabha MP in the hallowed chamber of the Chairman, CP Radhakrishnan, in the august presence of a galaxy of BJP’s top central ministers, he seemed to have turned a loner.

Certainly, Kumar’s removal as Chief Minister and travel to Delhi is unceremonious. Seemingly, it has not brought any joy to either him or his supporters. At the same time, his weakening position has also put a big question mark on the future of Janata Dal (U), with the prying BJP strategists on the prowl, eyeing its political base.

This should worry Kumar in the light of the recent developments in Odisha, where the same strategists had proactively cornered the old and trusted BJP ally, Biju Janata Dal. Not only is the party chief and former Chief Minister, Naveen Patnaik, nursing his wounds after an electoral defeat at the hands of his old ally, but more appallingly, he found his illustrious father, top-ranking political leader, freedom fighter, and an ace fighter pilot, Biju Patnaik, being targeted by a lesser mortal among the BJP ranks, allegedly describing him as a CIA agent, only to retract under pressure.

It is to Kumar’s credit that he did not encourage dynastic politics, particularly in his own family, unlike his old friends Yadav and Paswan, as the wards of both are now controlling their political parties. A political situation has arisen, or has been created, where a beleaguered Kumar has been forced to bring his son into politics at a time when he does not seem to be in command.

Samrat Choudhary, as the BJP nominee to replace Kumar as Chief Minister, is not the happiest of auguries, particularly for the people of Bihar, who had voted the ruling alliance back to power in the last Assembly elections in the name of Nitish Kumar. One should not be surprised if the people of Bihar are gripped by a sense of betrayal and blame him for the current transition of power in the state.

In any case, Choudhary has a tough task to step into the shoes of Kumar. Already mired in controversies on account of his educational qualifications and personal track record, there is a question mark on whether he has the capability and capacity to take independent decisions and resist pressure from New Delhi.

Nevertheless, Kumar’s “gain” in getting his Rajya Sabha “ambition” fulfilled is a net loss for the people of Bihar. Since Choudhary is an outsider in the BJP-RSS spectrum, it will be interesting to see how the old guard and loyalists in the Sangh Parivar react to the situation in the months to come.

The writer is a political and national affairs analyst

 dailypioneer
 @dhounti
 dailypioneer

Inside GenZ’s political mind



RANGAM TRIVEDI

India’s political conversation is quietly being reshaped by a generation that grew up with smartphones, digital payments, and real-time information. Urban Gen Z voters, those between 18 and 22 today, do not evaluate politics through the traditional lenses of ideology or party loyalty. Instead, they assess leadership much like they evaluate apps or start-ups: by performance, usability, and outcomes.

Forget the stereotype of the “distracted teen.” After my informal interactions with over 1,000 urban Gen Z respondents in Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Ahmedabad recently, I found a demographic that is deeply analytical and surprisingly pragmatic. For this cohort, politics is about a ‘market-fit product’. When looking at the two primary faces of Indian politics, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and LoP Rahul Gandhi, this urban demographic is leaning towards the former because his governance style hits the specific “likes” of a generation raised on efficiency.

Two of the highest “likes” in our interactions were “performance-driven leadership” and “measurable outcomes”. PM Modi’s mantra, “We inaugurate what we lay the foundation for,” resonates with a generation that values speed over rhetoric.

For an undergraduate Gen Z, witnessing India become the world’s third-largest start-up ecosystem with over 2 lakh start-ups within a decade of the Startup India Mission is a lived reality. This is also visible in the rapid execution of the India AI Mission, with India ranking third in the Global AI Competitive Index by Stanford and hosting a global AI summit within just two years of its launch. Similarly, the India Semiconductor Mission saw the Sanand plant inaugurated in just 900 days from its foundation, with nine more coming up in less than five years of its launch. From the world’s tallest rail bridge (Chenab) to the Atal Setu and Sela Tunnel, these mega projects were completed in record time, shattering the “decades of delay” seen under previous Congress-led governments. These are not just headlines; they are lifestyle upgrades delivered by their leader, instilling a firm belief in these youngsters that their future in India is exceptionally bright.

Urban Gen Z’s political views have moved towards meritocracy and consistency, creating a clear disconnect with Rahul Gandhi. This hustling generation often sees Rahul Gandhi as a “part-time politician”. His legislative record shows 51 per cent attendance in the 17th Lok Sabha, 52 per cent in the 16th, and 43 per cent in the 15th. His frequent absence from key debates in Parliament during important discussions, often due to trips abroad,

falls below national averages and suggests a lack of commitment. For young voters, holding on to ‘supreme leader’ status solely due to dynastic succession after nearly 100 electoral losses goes against the merit-based culture that Gen Z values.

Moreover, Rahul Gandhi’s approach to negative politics, which includes endorsing negative slogans like “Modi teri kabra khudegi” and supporting the “shirtless protest” at the India AI Impact Summit, conflicts with a generation that wants a constructive approach. By reportedly praising those who tried disrupting a global tech summit in front of foreign delegates, Gen Z says he chose a political stunt over India’s global reputation. This attitude against development, opposing every pro-people decision, and engaging in “propaganda politics” from abroad suggests a leadership based on conflict rather than policy. In the end, Rahul Gandhi’s focus on caste-based discriminatory politics and attacks on democratic institutions makes his style harder to connect with for a development- and innovation-driven Gen Z.

For Gen Z professionals in commerce and tech, the opposition’s dismissal of “Make in India” and UPI has been decisively debunked by a high-performance economic reality. In FY 2025, India’s total exports hit a record \$825.3 billion, bolstered by a 73 per cent surge in FDI (\$47 billion). Among its highlights is India’s ascent as the world’s second-largest mobile manufacturing hub and smartphones becoming the top export category in FY 25. Simultaneously, UPI has democratised finance, handling 50 per cent of global real-time payments with a monthly average of \$20 billion transactions in FY 25-26, all fuelled by the world’s cheapest data at ₹8-9/GB even in the far corners of the country. Beyond domestic success, PM Modi’s reception of

top civilian honours from 29 nations, recent landmark trade deals with the UK and USA, and secured energy corridors through the Strait of Hormuz for India’s

energy vessels during the West Asia crisis signal a level of global stature. To a generation prioritising tangible results over political rhetoric, Rahul Gandhi’s perceived anti-development stance feels like a direct threat to their career trajectory, cementing their alignment with the visionary leadership of PM Modi focused on a “Viksit Bharat”. Today, India’s median age is around 29 years, rising to 38 by 2047 — making Viksit Bharat a vision for today’s Gen Z. While Rahul Gandhi instigates youth to stand against democratic institutions, PM Modi inspires through his vision of bringing 1 lakh youth from non-political backgrounds into politics to end the rot of nepotism and build Viksit Bharat. Gen Z chooses PM Modi’s inspiration over negative narratives because they see a leader spending every minute for the nation. Standing by his side, they are the architects of 2047, choosing a future built on development rather than an anti-growth agenda.

The writer is a Founder, Bhavya Bharat Foundation & Socio-Political Youth activist Public Policy Researcher

 dailypioneer
 @RangamT
 rangamt

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

BLASÉ CAPITAL

CHINA CHIMES

Even as the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) reduced India's growth figures over the next two quarters (April-September 2026), China seems to be on a comeback trail. After a weak growth of 4.5 per cent in the previous (October-December 2025) quarter, its economy grew by five per cent in January-March 2026, or 0.2 per cent higher than the experts' estimate. The five per cent mark seems crucial because last month, Beijing deliberately cut its annual growth target to 4.5-5 per cent, "its lowest expansion goal since 1991." Touching five per cent, or the highest figure within the range, a quarter later is a positive sign.

More importantly, despite the Iran war, and West Asian disruptions in oil supplies and trade, the higher growth was driven by manufacturing. This was despite the negative and ongoing fallout due to the "falling property investment" in the country. Exports, especially of cars, marked a "major bright spot," which is surprising in the wake of global disruptions, and decline in growth predictions of most economies. Maybe there was an economic momentum in March, after the war began, and the real impact may show in the next quarter. Experts feel that the figure will be "weaker" in the April-July period.

This is evident from the export performance in March 2026. According to a media report, "China's export growth slowed sharply to 2.5 per cent last month, compared to the same time last year," and this is a "six-month low, and comes after the combined exports for January and February jumped by more than 20 per cent compared to a year before." Thus, the high export traction in the first two months of the previous quarter boosted manufacturing, and fueled the quarterly growth despite a dip in the exports in March. If the last is an indication, the decline may continue in April, and pull down the growth figures.

One need not forget that India's growth in the last quarter (January-March) was excellent, about 7.5 per cent, although the numbers for the next two quarters are quite low, 6.8 per cent and 6.7 per cent, respectively. China may follow the same trajectory if the March exports are any indication. Unless, of course, the war stops with the second round of talks between the US and Iran on the anvil. Indeed, Donald Trump said that China would be extremely happy if peace prevails, and oil bottlenecks open. He added that Xi Jinping will give him a big hug for ending the ongoing conflict with Iran.

Apart from the fall in exports in March 2026, Chinese imports surged by nearly 28 per cent, according to the official figures. One of the reasons may be the urgency to import goods in the first two weeks before the major routes were completely shut and closed. The second may be due to the high global crude oil prices, which went up by 50 per cent or so before they settled down below \$100 a barrel. China increased its purchases from Iran and Russia, and paid premiums over the high market prices. This pushed up the value of imports.

China's trade surplus in March, or the difference between export earnings and expenditure on imports, was \$50 billion, or the lowest number in a year, thanks to high imports and dip in exports. The trade numbers seem uncertain in the next few months. According to an expert, "The war could hit China's exports if consumers around the world are less willing to spend due to higher prices caused by the conflict. Export growth ultimately depends on your trading partners' economies. It is hard to sustain that growth at a very high rate continuously."

Due to the war, world agencies like the World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF) have trimmed the growth estimates for most economies. This week, it reduced China's number to 4.4 per cent growth in 2026, or lower than the range set by Beijing last month. In the case of India, the figure is 6.4 per cent each for 2026 and 2027. But the RBI feels that India can bounce back easily to over seven per cent in the last two quarters of 2026-27. However, what is interesting is that the central bank's estimate for 2027-28 is lower.

One is not sure what this implies. It may mean that the RBI expects the economy to move upwards after the Iran war ends. But the lag effects of the trends may hit India more so in 2027-28. One can possibly assume that the experts feel that despite the current macro robustness, there are weaknesses that may awaken after a few quarters. For example, if inflation increases due to the war, as it has, and as the RBI predicts for the future, prices have a nasty habit of not coming down. They persist at the higher levels despite the absence of the initial factors that made them go up. This may prove to be a negative.

China too may get out of the clutches of the war, if it ends soon, but continue to face other nagging problems. According to experts, these include a boost in public investment, and household demand. If these two do not happen, they may intensify deflationary pressures.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | APRIL 17, 2026

BUSINESS10

H-1B lottery with salary twist

New selection mode, higher fees help to improve visa chances

OUR TAKE

The first H-1B visa lottery, although it is a travesty to call it that, under new norms and fees, seems to have helped the Indian and US firms, applicants, and American administration. The first impressions, based on media reports, and not on official data that was not released, the selection and success rates improved dramatically. This implies that the chances of the applicants, as well as the firms went up, went up, although we are sure that the entire quota was filled up, or the higher success rate would not mean anything in practical terms.

According to several law firms, the winning chances went up to 50-60 per cent, or 1:2 or more. This implies that the applications of at least one out of two applicants were approved. The ratio is much higher than the 1:3, or one out of three, under the old lottery system. The old regime, apart from lower fees, was based on random selection, where the applications were put in a single pool, and selection was done through a random computerised system. Any name could crop up based on luck and destiny. The way to game it was to pile the system with enough applications to secure a reasonable win ratio.

Under the new system, which is still called a lottery for no rhyme or reason, the applications are stacked up as per salaries. The one with the highest salary is on the top, followed by lower ones subsequently, in a descending order. The top 65,000, which is the requisite quota, are automatically selected. Randomness, luck, and destiny do not play any role. Only the salary does. In this sense, it is not a lottery, or it is a

lottery to the extent that the applicants and firms are unaware of the salaries of the competitors and, hence, are unsure if their names will come in the list of the top 65,000. Indeed, if they fail to get the visa, they may never know the cut-off salary unless officials disclose it.

However, the better success rate can be explained by various factors. The first is that the high visa fees of \$1,00,000 dissuaded several applicants, firms, and institutions, which stayed away from the so-called salary-based lottery. For example, according to reports, academic institutions, universities, and hospitals "halted almost all their international recruiting as they cannot pay the exorbitant fee."

Even tech firms and US clients, which normally queue up for the visas, and accounted for 40 per cent of the applications in the previous years, stayed away. Either they too did not wish to pay the high fee, or they did not want to recruit highly-paid foreigners.

Over the past few years, before Donald Trump's second term as the US president, and before the new norms were implemented, Indian IT had deliberately decided to stay away from H-1Bs, and reduce their reliance on them. Media reports indicate that the hirings under it had reduced considerably in the past 2-3 years. Even the Indian IT minister said that the visa did not feature in the India-US bilateral trade talks because the IT industry was not enthusiastic about it. Dependence on AI, both by Indian IT and American clients, dented visa demand.

In effect, it is logical to assume that the number of applications this time, for various reasons, plummeted. Hence, the pool of applications was a lot smaller than the previous years. Indeed, as we stated earlier, there was no reason to game the system through excessive applications given the new norms that are based on salaries, and not random chance. Once, the overall numbers of applications reduce, and the quota remains the same, it is evident that the success or selection rate will invariably go up.

For it to almost double, from 33 per cent on average to 50-60 per cent, implies that the only reason was the shrinkage in the pool.

One can contend that this is good news for the applicants, who may know for certain that their chances of getting the visa is 50 per cent. The same goes for the firms, both in India and the US. If the US filled up the quota in one go, in this lottery, the official revenues will zoom, thanks to the visa fee of \$1,00,000. A net of 65,000, plus an additional 20,000 later, implies an inflow of \$6.5-8.5 billion. Since the success rate is 50-60 per cent, it means that the number of applications were at least more than 1,00,000, and possibly up to 1,30,000.

For the American job seekers, the salary-based so-called lottery implies that the jobs at the lower level, especially entry-level, freshers, and first-timers are open to them. This is a positive as recent reports indicate that joblessness among the American graduates, post-graduates, and doctorates is among the highest in recent times. Most of the highly-educated people fail to find jobs, either because they are unavailable, or the applicants do not like what they get. On the flip side, more Indians, and outsiders will grab the lucrative mid- and senior-level jobs that attract higher salaries.

In the future, such high-ranking foreigners may manage large IT or tech teams, which will include the majority of Americans at the lower levels, with lower salaries. The power structure, management hierarchies, and salary structures may undergo a change. The better jobs will go to the outsiders, and the lower ones to the Americans. In the next five years or a decade, it may lead to fresh controversies and charges about how the foreigners capture lucrative jobs, while the puny, meaningless, and irrelevant ones come to the Americans. Today, critics talk about cheap jobs to foreigners, which outwit the Americans. Tomorrow, they will be concerned with joblessness at the top.

Indians too will be on the back foot. Tens of thousands of students used to spend huge sums, funded via sale of assets and personal loans, to study in the US. The hope, desire, ambition, and confidence were that they would land American jobs, via H-1Bs, earn enough to repay the loans, and either remain in the US, or come back after a few years. Such choices and options are out the window. The salary-based lottery system has virtually shut them off. No firm will pay a \$1,00,000 fee, and pay a high salary to a fresher to crack the visa selection code. Hence, they will remain out, or seek their future elsewhere.

The Tech Wrecker

What is wrong with IT culture?

It is not about business. It is about social and political issues too

(IT firms) locations. Thus, they are both a part of the IT workplaces, and not a part of it. Since their salaries are negotiated by the external HR firms, the IT firms have no idea of how they are paid, how much they are paid, and what are their employment rules. It is a hands-off approach.

The IT firms stipulate hiring budgets, and HR firms adhere to them. Obviously, several malpractices occur. The HR firms tend to cut costs to boost profits. They renege on salary promises, and pay 10-30 per cent lower to the employees, who have little options but to work until they find employment elsewhere, which is difficult given the huge layoffs in the recent past. The increments are irregular, if they happen, and bonuses are possibly out of the question. The practice is to hire such employees only for two years, after which they cannot work for the same client, or even be

hired by the same HR firms.

Most employees, even if they are hired by the HR firms, think that they work for the large IT firms, both Indian and foreign. Thus, they feel cheated when they are short-changed, and feel that the fault lies with the IT firms, and not the HR firms. If their salaries are ducked, or bonuses do not come, they blame the IT giants. This explains why the complaints against them have gone up in the recent past. As an expert says, IT firms scaled rapidly through mass hirings. But the model is under pressure with different forms of hirings, coupled with layoffs.

According to a media report, "Earlier this year, employees speaking anonymously alleged that performance ratings were being systematically downgraded, particularly of mid-level staff, effectively reducing variable pay, and nudging some toward voluntary exits. The

company denied any changes to its compensation structure." As per an ex-executive quoted in a report, "The responses increasingly appear less like isolated lapses, and more like signs of a management culture that risks conflating institutional stature with immunity from scrutiny." Another expert says that "business is changing, and companies must balance shareholder expectations with workforce realities."

In most cases, the societies, politics, and culture of the smaller towns and cities, where more of the IT campuses are built, are different from say, Mumbai, Noida, Gurugram, or Bengaluru. The workplaces are different, even if the reputed and renowned employers impose the same rules, regulations, processes, and systems. How these are followed, and implemented differ, and this is complicated if the hirings are by external recruiting agencies rather than the IT firms. Hence, new workplaces evolve differently, and diverge from established norms. Thus, the chances of malpractices and irregularities are higher.

Hence, it is not surprising that some American senators have questioned the hiring-firing practices of the Indian IT firms. Indeed, during the past controversies related to H-1B visas, which resulted in major changes in rules, the elected representatives wanted to know the number of employees that are hired directly, and those through external HR firms. They knew that this was rampant, and obviously led to discrepancies and abuses of the employees in the form of lower pays, not-so-transparent work culture, and other practices. The entry of cheap IT labour in the US was questioned for decades.

Both TCS and Infosys have been hit by business and corporate governance issues. The former is caught between the tussle between Tata Sons, the parent, and Tata Trusts, and ego and other clashes between seniormost executives and trustees. Dividend payments by TCS to Tata Sons is a point of discussion in mainstream media. The fate of Infosys' existing business model hangs in a balance in the age of AI. One is not sure how the firm will survive, and what will be its new shape and form. Thus, both the firms are going through a churn that may change them forever. The employees and employers are caught within their own cross-wires, with their own issues.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

West Asia Conflict: Inbound tourism dips 15-20 per cent

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's inbound tourist traffic declined 15-20 per cent since the West Asia crisis broke out, while the aviation industry is staring at an estimated net loss of ₹18,000 crore following disruptions caused by the conflict, according to a report on the impact of the West Asia conflict released on Thursday.

The report, titled "Impact of the West Asia Conflict on India's Tourism, Aviation & Hospitality Sectors", highlighted that the aviation sector was the most impacted, with airlines facing flight cancellations, airspace

restrictions and significant rerouting of international flights. These disruptions have increased flying time by 2-4 hours on key routes, resulting in a sharp rise in fuel consumption and operating costs.

Industry estimates indicate that fuel accounts for 35-40 per cent of airline operating costs, and the ongoing situation has further strained airline profitability. The disruption of West Asia air corridors, which is among the busiest global transit routes, has also reduced connectivity efficiency and increased airfares, the report said.

The overall industry impact, including the estimat-

ed ₹18,000 crore net loss, has been assessed by rating agency Ibra by examining stakeholder feedback with sectoral trends, booking patterns, cancellations and operational cost pressures (particularly aviation-related), PHDCCI said.

India's inbound tourist traffic declined 15-20 per cent, particularly in leisure travel, as global travellers adopt a cautious approach amid geopolitical uncertainties, according to the report.

The findings are based on industry inputs collected through structured interviews and questionnaires with key stakeholders. The assessment covers the period



from 28 February 2026 onwards, marking the onset of the West Asia conflict and its subsequent impact on travel sentiment, flight operations and inbound tourism flows. The restaurant and

food services sector is also experiencing a mixed impact. According to industry estimates aligned with insights from the National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI), the sector is facing input cost

inflation in the range of 10-15 per cent, driven by higher prices of imported ingredients, logistics and energy.

Sagar Daryani, President, National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI), said the scale of the disruption has now become a nationwide operational challenge.

"The ongoing LPG supply disruption has created a serious operational crisis for the restaurant industry. Nearly 10 per cent of restaurants have temporarily shut down, while 60-70 of establishments have shifted to induction cooking, alternate fuels, reduced menus or shorter operating hours to manage limited supplies,"

Daryani said. According to the report, the economic implications of the disruption are substantial.

Citing industry estimates, it said the Indian food services market, valued at ₹5.69 lakh crore in 2024, projected to reach ₹7.76 lakh crore by 2028, is expected to reach an estimated ₹6.46 lakh crore in 2026, translating into approximately ₹17,700 crore in daily economic activity across the sector. A 15-20 per cent slowdown in throughput, as currently observed, corresponds to an estimated ₹2,650 crore reduction in daily economic activity, or nearly ₹79,000 crore per month, representing a significant economic

shock to the food services ecosystem, the report stated. Beyond operational and financial challenges, the disruption also raises concerns about employment stability across the sector.

The restaurant industry directly employs over 8.5 million people, making it one of the largest job creators in India's service economy.

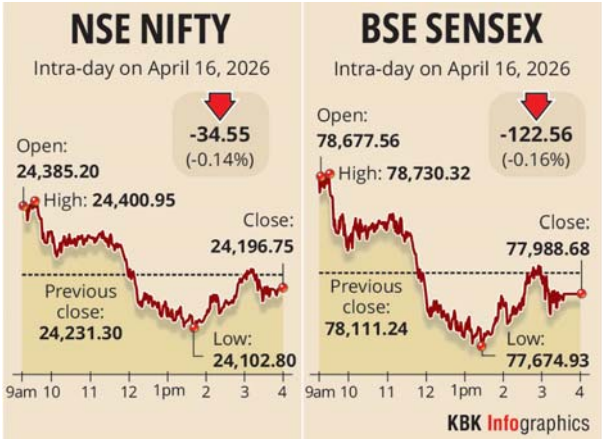
"Prolonged supply disruptions could therefore result in 5-7 lakh potential job losses, alongside hiring freezes and delayed expansion plans, particularly among small and medium-sized operators who are more vulnerable to cost and supply volatility," it added.

Stock markets close lower on profit-taking

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock markets closed lower in a volatile session on Thursday with the benchmark Sensex declining by 122 points and Nifty closing below 24,200, dragged by profit-taking in banking and financial shares after a recent sharp rally.

Erasing its early gains, the 30-share BSE Sensex declined 122.56 points or 0.16 per cent to settle at 77,988.68. The index opened higher and hit a high of 78,730.32 in late-morning trading. However, profit-taking emerged at higher levels, dragging the index down to a low of 77,674.93. The index gyrated 1,055.39 points during the session. The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 34.55 points or



0.14 per cent to end at 24,196.75. The index moved between a high of 24,400.95 and a low of 24,102.80 during the session. The two key indices had surged by more than 1 per cent on

Wednesday following easing geopolitical tensions.

Among the 30-Sensex firms, HDFC Bank fell the most by 1.75 per cent. Titan, Mahindra & Mahindra, Bharti Airtel, Kotak Mahindra Bank

and Bajaj Finance were the major laggards.

Trent, Eternal, Adani Ports, Bharat Electronics and Infosys were among the major winners. "Indian markets witnessed a volatile session today, reflecting a shift from directional momentum to consolidation after the recent sharp recovery. The index opened on a positive note, supported by improving global cues and easing geopolitical concerns, but failed to sustain higher levels as profit booking emerged through the day," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

From a macro perspective, sentiment remains sensitive to developments in the Middle East, he said.

Rupee rises 10 paise to settle at 93.23 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee strengthened by 10 paise to settle at 93.23 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, following a decline in global crude oil prices amid hopes of a truce in West Asia.

However, sustained outflow of foreign capital amid increased dollar demand from importers capped the gain in the local currency, forex traders said, adding that the domestic unit rose after crude oil prices hovered around \$95-a-barrel.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 93.29 and touched an intraday high of 93.16 against the green-



back. It also fell to the day's low of 93.35 before ending the session at 93.23 (provisional) against the dollar, registering a rise of 10 paise from the previous closing level.

On Wednesday, the rupee gained 2 paise to settle at 93.33 against the US dollar.

Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said the rupee's gains are largely driven by de-escalation hopes between the US and Iran, which have led to a decline in crude oil prices over the last 48 hours, easing pressure on India's import bill.

"However, the recovery remains fragile, as markets continue to track geopolitical developments closely, and any reversal in crude could quickly impact the rupee. The rupee range can be seen between 92.75-93.75," Trivedi said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, surged by 0.18 per cent at 98.03.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading up 1.65 per cent at \$96.50 per barrel in futures trade. Crude oil prices fell below \$100/barrel amid expectations that the crisis in West Asia would end soon.

In a latest development on the geopolitical front, China, a close ally of Iran and the largest importer of Iranian oil, has asked Tehran to ensure freedom and safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz, the key international trade route.

Renault Group announces 'FutuREady' plan for India Plans to launch seven new model by 2030, including Duster

KUSHAN MITRA
■ Chennai

Renault Group Chief Executive Officer, Francois Provost today unveiled the French car manufacturers' 'FutuREady' plan for India until 2030. This will see Renault launch seven new models by 2030 starting with the recently launched Duster.

The plan envisages Renault achieving five percent market share by 2030 and also dramatically expanding exports which are expected to touch \$2 billion in the same timeframe.

Additionally, the plans include the launch of an all-new platform — RGEF which will replace the existing CMF-A platform. New versions of the Kiger and Triber on this new platform are expected to be launched soon and will



Stephan Deblaise, Renault Group India receives the 'FutuREady' plans from Renault Group CEO Francois Provost in Chennai

support underfloor factory-footed CNG options.

It was also announced that the new Bridger sub-4m SUV will be Renault's first electric vehicle in India but will also feature a brand-new 1.2 Turbo petrol engine. This new vehicle is planned to be launched in late-2027.

Speaking to The Pioneer, Stephan Deblaise, Chief Executive Officer, Renault Group India, also highlighted that the company is expected to launch several hybrid options.

"We are also exploring the possibility of a 'Super Hybrid' which can be compared to a plug-in extended range hybrid. Our experience in Brazil can also allow us to introduce flex-fuel vehicles if necessary."

Deblaise also praised the Delhi Government's new

draft EV policy that gives tax incentives to strong hybrid vehicles. "Hybrid vehicles offer a significant 30 per cent reduction in the carbon footprint without the need to add charging infrastructure. I believe giving incentives to hybrids is an extremely positive step and our plans to launch a hybrid variant of the Duster remains on track for the festive season this year."

Speaking about the current geopolitical challenges, Deblaise added that it had made consumers across the world consider battery electric vehicles more seriously.

"Carmakers make very long lead times of development and one crisis doesn't really change progress but clearly, there is some change in consumer behaviour across the world thanks to the problems in West Asia."

Asia will remain main driver of global growth: IMF

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Asia will remain the main driver of global growth with India and China contributing 70 per cent of the regional expansion, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) said Thursday, adding that the energy shock due to the Gulf crisis will negatively impact the region.

However, the five per cent regional growth witnessed in 2025, despite the impact of US tariffs and trade uncertainty, is projected to moderate to 4.4 per cent in 2026 and 4.2 per cent in 2027, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) said in its report on the Asia-Pacific segment.

"Asia entered 2026 on a solid footing with growth remaining resilient despite the region bearing the brunt



of US tariffs and heightened uncertainty," Krishna Srinivasan, Director for the IMF Asia Pacific Department told reporters here.

However, he said, given the region's high fossil fuel intensity and reliance on conflict areas for key commodities, the new energy shock will negatively impact the region.

"The shock is raising inflation, weakening external balances, tightening financial conditions, and narrow-

ing policy space," he said.

According to the IMF, Asia consumes about 38 per cent of the world's oil and 24 per cent of its natural gas.

It's also one of the largest crude refiners, accounting for about 35 per cent of global refining capacity, which is heavily concentrated in China, India, Korea, and Singapore.

Srinivasan said growth across most Asian economies turned out stronger than expected in late 2025.

This is thanks to exports and consumption which held up better than anticipated, supported by accommodative policies and financial conditions.

"Asia's exports to the US declined but that to the rest of the world increased," he said. (PTI)

EU's proposed CBAM expansion may impact Indian exporters: GTRI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The European Union is planning an expansion of its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) and the move could increase carbon tax costs on Indian manufactured exports to Europe, think tank GTRI said on Thursday.



It said that Indian exporters selling into Europe may need to accelerate emissions accounting, supply-chain traceability, and decarbonisation investments to remain competitive in one of the country's key export markets.

In a draft report issued on April 10, 2026, the European Parliament's Committee on the Environment, Climate and Food Safety (ENVI) proposed five major changes to the CBAM regime.

The changes include extending CBAM to around 180 additional steel- and aluminium-based manufactured products from January 1, 2028; and tightening carbon accounting rules for scrap-based production by including emissions from pre-con-

sumer scrap, the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said.

It also includes examining expansion of the mechanism to indirect emissions from electricity use across more sectors. "Together, these steps would turn CBAM from a tax mainly on steel and aluminium raw materials into a much wider carbon tax cov-

ering manufactured industrial goods," GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

CBAM is the EU's border carbon tax that charges importers for emissions embedded in goods produced outside Europe.

It effectively places a carbon price on foreign manufacturers selling into the EU. The mechanism acts as a climate-linked trade barrier on carbon-intensive imports.

He said that the proposed expansion would bring many new products under CBAM, including fabricated metal products, tubes, pipes, fasteners, structural components, machinery parts, aluminium containers, and other semi-finished and finished engineering goods.

India to clock 6.3% growth even with crude at \$130/barrel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

S&P Global Ratings on Thursday said India is expected to grow at 6.3 per cent if the oil price averages \$130/barrel in the current fiscal year amid the West Asia crisis.

It also said that the fiscal strain from the energy price shock is unlikely to impact India's sovereign credit rating, as India has the "political commitment to fiscal consolidation" over the long term. S&P Director, Sovereign and International



Public Finance Ratings, Yee Farn Phua said considering a baseline assumption of crude at \$85/barrel, India

will grow 7.1 per cent in 2026-27. "That's still a very strong number compared to any major economies out

there. Even in the alternate scenario, if I were to say, \$130/barrel average, we are still looking at the growth at 6.3 per cent... that is still going to be the highest among major economies," Phua said at a webinar.

S&P said energy supply disruptions that lead to fuel rationing or shortages of related products, such as fertilisers, would be a risk.

India, S&P said, could see a weaker current account balance, higher costs for producers squeezing margins, higher consumer prices reducing purchasing

power, and fiscal strains, as the government steps in to cushion some of the shock for consumers.

"The government's fiscal consolidation efforts continue to be very strong... India has a lot of physical flexibility on the spending side, especially on infrastructure. So, in case some of the areas where they have to spend more, for example, the subsidy bill, they might cut in other places to make sure that they will still hit the fiscal deficit target," Phua added.

Ladakh-LuLu pact to push 1,000 MT Apricots into global markets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Leh

In a major boost to the horticulture sector, the Ladakh Administration on Thursday signed a Memorandum of Understanding with LuLu Retail to export 1,000 tonnes of premium Ladakhi apricots to international markets this season.

The agreement marks a dramatic scale-up from just 1,500 kg (1.5 tonnes) of apricots exported over the last two years, signalling a new phase of market access, value addition and global visibility for the region's produce, an official said.

Consequent to a major push by Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena, for promoting the branding and export of Ladakh's GI-tagged "Raktsey Karmo" apricot variety, as well as the region-specific "Halman variety", the Union Territory Administration



signed the MoU with global conglomerate, UAE-based LuLu Retail, for the export of 1,000 tonnes of apricots this season, which is a historic first for the region, an official spokesperson said.

On Wednesday, the Lt Governor held a meeting with representatives of the LuLu Retail and APEDA to finalise the export potential.

The MoU has been signed with LuLu Retail through the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA) and the Ministry of Food Processing Industry (MOFPI), Government of India, the spokesman said. He said the MoU was signed by Bhupesh Chaudhary, Secretary, Horticulture, UT Administration and Salim MA, Group Director — Global Operations, LuLu Retail, in the presence of the Lt Governor.

LuLu Retail, a leading retailer in the Gulf region, will procure at least 1,000 tonnes of apricots from the farmers in Ladakh this season and process, package and market the product in international markets, while upholding the identity of Ladakh, the spokesman said.

As of now, he said the farmers face a tough time sorting, cleaning,

packaging and marketing apricots using traditional methods that often lead to heavy losses during processing and packaging.

However, with the MoU in place, the farmers, at the time of harvest, will hand over their apricot fields to the exporter that will be responsible for plucking, sorting, processing, packaging, transporting and marketing of the product in the international markets, the spokesman said.

The Lt Governor said this would ensure minimal loss of the produce and would also earn fair pricing for the farmers. "The unique apricots of Ladakh are an agricultural heritage of this region. The MoU aims at tapping the immense yet under-utilised potential of apricot cultivation in Ladakh, which is known for producing the finest apricot varieties in the world," Saxena said.

Wipro Q4 profit slides 1.8% to ₹3,502 crore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Wipro on Thursday reported 1.89 per cent decline in March quarter FY26 consolidated net profit at ₹3,501.8 crore. The IT company's profit in the year-ago period stood at ₹3,569.6 crore.

Revenue from operations rose 7.6 per cent to ₹24,236.3 crore in the fourth quarter of FY26, according to a regulatory filing. As compared to previous December quarter,



profit and revenue rose by 12.2 per cent and 2.8 per cent, respectively. For full fiscal year 2025-26, Wipro recorded a net profit of ₹13,197.4 crore, reflecting a marginal 0.47 per cent increase from 2024-25.

FY26 revenue stood 3.96 per cent higher at ₹92,624 crore. "Advancements in AI are reshaping client priorities and creating new opportunities for us to partner more deeply to deliver value-driven outcomes. To strengthen our position in an AI-first world, we are pivoting to a services-as-a-software model through the AI Native Business & Platforms unit," Wipro CEO and MD Srinipallia said.

FROM THE WORLD

VIETNAM

Lionel Rosenblatt died at 82

Lionel Rosenblatt, who as a US Foreign Service Officer carried out an unauthorised evacuation of hundreds of Vietnamese citizens before the 1975 fall of Saigon, has died at age 82. The episode set off a career as a high-profile advocate for refugee rights. Rosenblatt was president of the Washington-based Refugees International from 1990 to 2001, and he lobbied for more active humanitarian intervention in crisis spots such as Bosnia and Rwanda. Rosenblatt died on Saturday in the Washington area after a battle with cancer. Refugees International President Jeremy Konyndyk recalled Rosenblatt as a "fierce, creative, passionate champion for refugees" who "helped to shape a generation of humanitarian leaders." Rosenblatt was especially devoted to helping refugees in Southeast Asia.

BANGLADESH

Court to review Hasina's charges

A court in Bangladesh on Friday will hear arguments on framing of charges in a seditious case against ousted prime minister Sheikh Hasina and 285 others. Dhaka Third Additional Metropolitan Sessions Judge Moin Uddin Chowdhury fixed the June 17 date, allowing a plea by the defence seeking more time, according to the state-run BSS news agency on Wednesday. The case relates to allegations that the accused were involved in anti-state activities and conspired to overthrow the then Muhammad Yunus-led interim Government by participating in a virtual "Joy Bangla Brigade" meeting on December 19, 2024. The meeting, attended by 577 participants worldwide, allegedly included pledges to incite rebellion and reinstate Hasina as prime minister. Joy Bangla Brigade is a strong supporter of Hasina's Awami League party and the legacy of her father.

Munir meets Iranian officials in Tehran to ease tension

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir on Thursday held talks with top Iranian leadership in Tehran as part of Islamabad's efforts to resolve the conflict between the US and Iran. Munir, who is heading a high-level political-security delegation to Iran, landed in Tehran on Wednesday, becoming the first foreign military leader to visit the country since a two-week ceasefire was agreed between Iran and the US last week. Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf met Chief of the Army Staff of the Pakistan Army Field Marshal Munir in Tehran on



Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi meets with Pakistan's Army Chief Field Marshal General Asim Munir in Tehran

Thursday, Iran's official IRNA news agency reported. Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi was also part of the

Pakistani delegation. Ghalibaf had led the Iranian delegation to Pakistan for talks with the US over the

weekend. Munir also visited the Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters of the Revolutionary Guards, where he met with its commander, according to IRNA.

During the meeting, he discussed with the commander of the IRGC the steps taken under the framework for ending the war and their recent talks in Tehran.

The two sides discussed the situation in the region and the prospects for peace and stability, Iranian official media reported.

Munir stressed that ongoing efforts to end the war should continue.

On Wednesday, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi received the Pakistani delegation. In a post on X, Araghchi

said he was delighted to welcome Field Marshal Munir to Iran.

"Expressed gratitude for Pakistan's gracious hosting of dialogue, emphasising that it reflects our deep and great bilateral relationship. Our commitment to promoting peace and stability in the region remains strong - and shared," said Araghchi.

The delegation later held a meeting with Araghchi and other Iranian officials.

Iran's state-run Press TV on Wednesday said the purpose of the visit is to deliver a US message to the Iranian leadership and to plan the next round of negotiations.

According to informed sources, Pakistan was working to bridge differences

between Iran and the US on the nuclear issues so that a draft could be agreed upon for finalisation at the second round of talks.

There are also reports that Iran may agree to third-party monitoring of its nuclear programme, possibly by four nations along with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA).

Sources said that Munir may undertake a visit to the US and meet with President Donald Trump to convince him of a final deal.

Earlier, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei confirmed that the exchange of messages continued with the US through Pakistan after Islamabad talks over the

weekend ended without a breakthrough.

US President Donald Trump on Tuesday said that a second round of talks with Iran could be held in Islamabad "over the next two days".

The US and Iran held rare direct talks in Pakistan over the weekend aimed at ending their conflict, but the talks ended early Sunday without any agreement.

US Vice President JD Vance, who led the American delegation, said the talks failed to reach a deal, citing Tehran not forgoing its nuclear programme as one of the key sticking points. Iran, however, said that the Islamabad talks failed due to "excessive demands" made by the American side. (PTI)

Pak's central bank confirms it received \$2 billion from Saudi Arabia



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi

Pakistan's central bank on Thursday confirmed that it has received from Saudi Arabia \$2 billion, part of the \$3 billion aid that Finance Minister Aurangzeb announced a day before.

The transfer of the funds - which has come as a major boost to the skewed foreign reserves - coincided with Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's visit to Saudi Arabia in a bid to promote peace in West Asia.

"The amount has been received on April 15, 2026," the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) said in a post.

Saudi Arabia on Tuesday extended its \$5 billion facility for a further three years and also pledged the additional \$3 billion deposits for Pakistan.

According to Finance Minister Aurangzeb, who is in the USA, the existing \$5 billion Saudi deposit would no longer be subject to the previous annual rollover arrangements and would be extended for a longer term.

China asks Iran to ensure freedom of navigation through Hormuz

KJM VARMA
Beijing

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi has asked Iran to ensure freedom and safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz, a first such call issued by Beijing ever since Tehran started to put a squeeze on the critical waterway in the midst of its war with the US.

Wang has sought guarantees of freedom and safety of international navigation through the Strait of Hormuz in a phone call with Iranian counterpart Abbas Araghchi on Wednesday.

Wang's call coincided with a Pakistan mediation delegation headed by Field Marshal Asim Munir reaching Tehran on Wednesday to discuss new peace proposals for a second round of talks between the US and Iran in Islamabad. China, a close ally of Iran



and the largest importer of Iranian oil, was also concerned over the energy crisis accentuated by the US blockade of the Strait, preventing

ships from carrying oil and gas from Iran's ports. The Strait of Hormuz is a vital 55-km-wide maritime choke point between Iran and Oman,

managing roughly 20 per cent of global oil trade. Opening of the Strait was the second most important demand by US President Donald Trump, besides halting Iran's nuclear energy.

"The current situation has reached a critical stage of transition between conflict and peace, and a window for peace is opening," Wang told Araghchi, according to a statement by the Chinese foreign ministry. Wang said Iran, as a coastal state of the Strait of Hormuz, should have its sovereignty, security and legitimate rights and interests respected and safeguarded.

"At the same time, the freedom and safety of international navigation through the strait should also be ensured, and efforts to restore normal transit through the strait are a shared call of the international

community," he said. Araghchi said Tehran expected China to play an active role in promoting peace and ending the conflict, and that Iran was willing to continue seeking a rational and realistic solution through peaceful negotiations, Hong Kong based South China Morning Post reported.

The US blockade followed an initial round of talks in Islamabad over the weekend that had aimed at permanently ending the conflict but failed to produce an agreement, with divisions remaining over thorny issues, particularly Iran's nuclear programme and the Strait of Hormuz.

The Chinese foreign ministry on Tuesday sharply criticised the US blockade as "dangerous and irresponsible", saying it risked escalating tensions and undermining the shaky ceasefire. (PTI)

Europe left with six weeks of jet fuel: IEA

JOHN LEICESTER
Paris

Europe has "maybe 6 weeks or so (of) jet fuel left," the head of the International Energy Agency said Thursday in a wide-ranging Associated Press interview, warning of possible flight cancellations "soon" if oil supplies remain blocked by the Iran war.

International Energy Agency (IEA) Executive Director Fatih Birol painted a sobering picture of the global repercussions of what he called "the largest energy crisis we have ever faced," stemming from the pinch-off of oil, gas and other vital supplies through



Fatih Birol

the Strait of Hormuz. "In the past there was a group called Dire Straits."

It's a dire strait now, and it is going to have major implications for the global economy. And the longer it goes, the worse it will be for the economic growth and inflation around the world," he said. (AP)

Houthi leader in Yemen blames the US in Iran talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Abdul Malik al-Houthi, leader of the Iran-backed Yemeni rebel group, said that in negotiations with Iran, the US is making "impossible demands for any independent country to accept."

During a video speech Thursday, he said the ongoing two-week ceasefire was a result of "failures" by the US and Israel to achieve their goals in the Iran war. "If negotiations succeed, it will either result in a longer period of stability or an end to the aggression," he said, adding that the US entered negotiations based on their own terms built on "arrogance and pride."



Lebanon Death Toll Reaches 2,196

Lebanon's Health Ministry on Thursday the death toll of Lebanese killed in Israeli strikes has increased to 2,196. The Health Ministry said that among the killed are 260 women and 172 children since the latest

war between Israel and Hezbollah began March 2. Another 7,185 have been wounded.

Israel's latest military escalation started after Hezbollah fired rockets towards northern Israel in solidarity with its key ally and patron Iran. Lebanon and Israel started direct

talks Tuesday, the first of their kind since 1993. Lebanon hopes those talks can end the war.

Aoun Refuses Netanyahu Phone Call

That's according to a Government official familiar with the developments.

The official, who spoke on condition of anonymity in line with regulations, said the remarks were made during a call with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and that Washington was "understanding of Lebanon's position." Aoun's office acknowledged a call with Rubio in a public statement, but did not mention the possibility of talks with Netanyahu. Netanyahu's office did not do so either.

Ghana rescues 305 West African nationals

EDWARD ACQUAH
Accra

More than 300 West African nationals, including 113 children, have been rescued after an intelligence-led bust by the Ghana Immigration Service on street begging networks in the capital of Accra, the agency said on Thursday.

The operation early Wednesday targeted suspected street begging rings exploiting foreign nationals linked to human trafficking across parts of the Greater Accra Region.

According to a US State Department report in 2024, Ghana does not meet the minimum standards for eliminating human trafficking despite efforts by the Government. It is a source,



transit and destination country for human trafficking in West Africa.

The country breakdown of the 305 nationals was not provided, but it is said to include 36 boys, 77 girls, 66 women and 126 men.

The agency said the high number of minors highlight-

ed growing concerns over the use of children in organised begging schemes linked to human trafficking, and the operation was carried out to disrupt networks that exploit foreign nationals, particularly women and children, often under coercive arrangements. (AP)

Australia boosts military spending amid Iran war

ROD MCGUIRK
Melbourne

The Iran war had greatly complicated the global strategic landscape, Defence Minister Richard Marles said Thursday as he announced a major increase in Australian military spending. Marles released the latest two-year update of Australia's defence strategy and said an additional \$3 billion Australian dollars (\$38 billion) in spending on defence was planned over the next decade.

Australia's defence budget would grow from 2.8 per cent of GDP this year to 3 per cent by 2033 as "Australia faces its most complex and threatening strategic circumstances since the end of World War II," Marles said.

Asked how much more complex and threatening Australia's circumstances were since the United States and Israel attacked Iran in February, Marles told reporters: "I don't think anyone could honestly answer that question." "It greatly complicates the global strate-



gic landscape," Marles said. "The world feels less safe." "Having said that, we do very much support the strategic objective of denying Iran a deployable nuclear weapon," Marles added.

Marles said his Government's decision to increase defence spending to 3 per cent of GDP was not a response to pressure from US President Donald Trump's administration. The Pentagon

released its own National Defence Strategy in January that chastised US allies to take control of their own security. The Australian Government was making its own resourcing decisions, Marles said. "What that has yielded to date is, under our Government, the biggest peacetime increase in defence spending that our nation has seen," Marles said.

The latest spending strategy would focus on Australian self-reliance, which should not be confused with military self-sufficiency, Marles said. "This is not about jettisoning alliance relationships. To the contrary, alliances, especially with the United States, will always be fundamental to Australia's defence," Marles said.

Australia's largest-ever defence investment is expected to be a fleet of at least eight submarines powered by US nuclear technology provided through the AUKUS partnership with the United States and Britain. (AP)

Indonesia reviews US proposal for airspace overflight access



EDNA TARIGAN
Jakarta

Indonesia is reviewing a US proposal on overflight access to its airspace, the Foreign Ministry said on Thursday.

The proposal surfaced in local media after Indonesia and the US established the Major Defence Cooperation Partnership, which was announced by US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth on Monday at the Pentagon. "It is still under internal consideration by the Government and the regulatory mechanism continues to be examined carefully.

And of course taking into account... Indonesia's national interests, airspace sovereignty and our independent and active foreign policy," Yvonne Mewengkang, spokesperson for Indonesia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, told reporters. The Indonesian Defence Ministry this week confirmed the US had asked for overflight clearance and that it was still under discussion. (AP)

Sudan enters fourth year of war as officials lament abandoned crisis

SAMY MAGDY/ SAM MEDNICK
Port Sudan

Sudan on Wednesday entered a fourth year of war that's been called an "abandoned crisis", as a new Middle East conflict throws into shadow the fighting that has forced 13 million people to flee their homes.

The North African country is described as the world's largest humanitarian challenge, notably in terms of displacement and hunger. There is no end in sight to the fighting between the military and the paramilitary group Rapid Support Forces, or RSF, which witnesses and aid groups say has laid waste to parts of the vast Darfur region. Growing evidence shows regional powers



like the United Arab Emirates backing rival combatants behind the scenes. Attempts by the United States and regional powers, now distracted by the Iran war, have failed to establish a ceasefire.

"We've lost so many people in this war," said Hussein Mohamed Shareef, running his fingers over the scar on his head where he said an RSF sniper had shot him in the city of Omdurman, near

Khartoum, Sudan's capital. He said at least 10 friends have been killed.

Numbers tell a tale of pain

At least 59,000 people have been killed. At least 6,000 died over three days as the RSF ramped through the Darfur outpost of el-Fasher in October, according to the United Nations, with UN-backed experts concluding that the offensive bore "the defining characteristics of genocide".

More than 11,000 people have gone missing over the course of the war, the Red Cross says. The war has pushed parts of Sudan into famine. The number of people with severe acute malnutrition, the most dangerous and deadly kind, is expected to increase to

800,000, the world's foremost experts on food security, the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification, said in February.

About 34 million people, or almost two out of three Sudanese, need assistance, the UN says.

Only 63 per cent of health facilities remain fully or partially functional amid disease outbreaks, including cholera, according to the World Health Organisation.

At a centre for malnourished children in the Red Sea city of Port Sudan, health staff weighed crying babies and fed some through a tube in their nose. The number of severely malnourished children entering the 16-bed centre has doubled since the war began, to 60 a week, staff said. Several children often must share a mat-

tress. "I don't know what will happen in the coming days," Dr. Osman Karrar said.

Now fuel prices in Sudan have increased by more than 24 per cent because of the Iran war and its effects on shipping, driving up food prices. "A plea from me: Please don't call this the forgotten crisis. I'm referring to this as an abandoned crisis," the top UN official in Sudan, Denise Brown, said on Monday, criticising the international community for failing to focus on ending the fighting.

The conflict exploded from a power struggle that emerged following Sudan's transition to democracy after an uprising forced the military ouster of long-time autocratic President Omar al-Bashir in April 2019. (AP)

Hundreds of Russian drones hit Ukraine, 16 killed

HANNA ARHIROVA/
VASILISA STEPANENKO
■ Kyiv

Russia hammered civilian areas of Ukraine with hundreds of drones and dozens of missiles in an attack that stretched for hours from daytime into the night, killing at least 16 people and injuring more than 80 others as terrified residents covered in their homes, officials said on Thursday.

Russia launched nearly 700 drones and dozens of ballistic and cruise missiles, primarily targeting civilians, in its biggest aerial barrage in almost two weeks, authorities said. Tetiana Sokol, a 54-year-old resident of Kyiv, said two missiles hit near her home and she took cover with her



A woman with a dog walks among the rubble of a house damaged after a Russian strike in Kyiv

dog in the hallway as flashes lit up the night and windows shattered from the blast wave. "On the third attack, everything broke, everything

flew, we were shocked, we didn't know where to run. I grabbed whatever came to hand and ran away with the dog," she told The Associated

Press. "I still can't find the cats in the house; they climbed out somewhere, I don't even know. No windows, nothing, the dog is still walking around

in stress." Moscow's forces have hit civilian areas almost daily since its all-out invasion of its neighbour more than four years ago, with the regular assaults occasionally punctuated by massive attacks. More than 15,000 Ukrainian civilians have died in the strikes, the United Nations says. Zelenskyy on a mission to improve air defences

The latest bombardment came in the wake of Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's 48-hour trip this week to Germany, Norway and Italy in an urgent search for more air defence systems that can stop Russian missiles.

Ukraine has developed a significant domestic arms

industry, especially in the production of drones and missiles, but it can't yet match the sophistication of US patriot air defence systems. Ukraine's top diplomatic priority is securing allies' help to buy and build more and better air defences, Zelenskyy said this week.

Ukraine fears the Iran war is burning through stockpiles of the advanced American-made systems it needs, and has argued against a US temporary waiver on Russian oil sanctions that Kyiv says is helping finance the Kremlin's war effort. "Another night has proven that Russia does not deserve any easing of global policy or lifting of sanctions," Zelenskyy said on X. (AP)

2 men plead not guilty in alleged bomb attempt outside New York city



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

Two men pleaded not guilty Wednesday to charges they brought homemade bombs to an anti-Islam protest outside New York City's mayor's home in a failed attempt at a terror attack inspired by the Islamic State group. Emir Balat (18) and Ibrahim Kayumi (19) entered the pleas during a brief appearance in federal court in Manhattan.

The two, who are both from the Philadelphia-area, face charges that include attempting to provide material support to a foreign terrorist organisation and using a weapon of mass destruction.

Prosecutors say Balat and Kayumi drove from their home state to Manhattan in order to attack a March 7 anti-Islam demonstration in front of Gracie Mansion.

The protest was hosted by Jake Lang, a far-right activist and critic of Mayor Zohran Mamdani, the first Muslim to hold the office.

Ukraine's Army reforms under fire, breaks Soviet legacy

HANNA ARHIROVA/
VASILISA STEPANENKO/
SAMYA KULLABBY
■ Kharkiv

When a Ukrainian agricultural tycoon founded a volunteer unit of 30 people in the early days of Russia's invasion, he had no certainty he would live to see what came next — but he did, and so did the force he created.

The group is now a 40,000-strong corps widely seen as one of Ukraine's most effective fighting formations within official defence forces.

"Ukraine needs to have an effective modern army. And this is our number one guarantee of the country's security," said Vsevolod



Kozhemyako, owner of a large agricultural conglomerate and now an adviser to the Commander of the Khartia Corps.

Its rapid expansion reflects a broader transformation of Ukraine's military, part of a new wave of formations, alongside the

Third Army and Azov Corps, breaking with Soviet-era practices long criticised by soldiers. As talks on a potential peace settlement stall and global attention shifts to the Middle East, Ukraine continues to seek firm security guarantees from its allies, particularly the United States. But for many in Ukraine, the war has reinforced a different conclusion: the country's strongest guarantee may ultimately be its own army.

"We have kids, we have grandkids, and we will stay on this territory," Kozhemyako said. "The future of this country depends on us."

After the Soviet Union collapsed, Ukraine inherited a

large military and arsenal. But by 2014, Russia's annexation of Crimea and armed conflict in eastern Ukraine exposed weaknesses from underinvestment, corruption and a lack of clear strategy, prompting an influx of volunteers and long-overdue military reforms.

Those changes helped Ukraine withstand the 2022 invasion, but as the war dragged on, some of its deepest problems — rigid top-down leadership, excessive bureaucracy and a culture where bad news is often hidden out of fear of punishment — began to reassert themselves, with consequences on the battlefield. From the outset, Kozhemyako said his unit

would have to take a different path. He said he understood the shortcomings of the regular army as an active military member since 2014, who was surrounded by veterans. "They didn't want to join the post-Soviet army, but they wanted to fight," Kozhemyako recalled.

Many of them were civilians with a background in business, he said. TLP allow lower-level units to plan operations faster, which is critical for exploiting narrow windows of opportunity on the battlefield. AAR push soldiers to identify what happened, why and how to improve, a process the corps has applied with particular rigour to its fast-evolving use of technology. (AP)

India, South Korea launch 2026 culture and innovation contest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Seoul

The Embassy of India in the Republic of Korea, the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Centre, and Korean English media outlet AJU PRESS have opened applications for the 2026 Korea-India Culture and Innovation Contest to foster public diplomacy through modern technology. This initiative arrives as Seoul and New Delhi increasingly leverage digital innovation to strengthen bilateral relations under the theme 'Our Moments and Future Captured in One Frame'.

The competition represents a strategic shift toward embracing the creative potential of AI. Participants can enter the AI Video Category, requiring content between 30 seconds and 1 minute, or the Essay Category, which calls for original works of approximately 2,500 words in English. To incentivise high-level participation, Grand Prize winners in both categories will receive



a travel voucher valued at approximately \$2,000 for travel between Seoul and New Delhi. The contest is officially sponsored by the Republic of Korea Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, alongside other important organisations. The submission period runs through April 30.

Applicants must register via the top banner of the AJU PRESS website at www.aju-press.com or by using a smartphone to access the QR code included in the article image. Results will be announced on May 13, followed by an awards ceremony on May 16.

Malema jailed for 5 years for firing at rally

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Johannesburg

A South African opposition party leader, Julius Malema, was sentenced to five years imprisonment on Thursday, after he was convicted of breaking firearm laws by firing a rifle at a political rally in 2018.

Malema was convicted in October on five counts, including unlawful possession of a firearm and ammunition, discharge of a firearm in a built-up area and reckless endangerment.

Delivering the sentence, Magistrate Twanet Olivier said she considered the



magnitude of the offence when she determined his sentence. "We hear daily, or weekly, of children playing in the front yards, in the street, who are caught in crossfire, random shots fired, killing people. It's just the first time that we hear, it's being called celebratory shots," Olivier said.

Death toll rises to 10 in Turkey school shooting

CINAR KIPER
■ Istanbul

The death toll from Turkey's second school shooting in two days rose to 10 Thursday after another victim died while being treated in hospital, authorities said.

Six of the wounded were in critical condition before the death early Thursday following the shooting the previous day, officials said.

Isa Aras Mersinli, 11, opened fire on two classrooms at a middle school in the southern city of Kahramanmaraş on Wednesday, killing a teacher and eight students and wounding 13 others.

The gunman, who was also killed, arrived at the school with five firearms and seven magazines belonging to his father, a retired police superintendent, who was arrested after the attack.

Wednesday's attack came just a day after 16 people were wounded when a former student opened fire at a high school in nearby Sanliurfa province. The victims were mostly students. The assailant later killed himself. As of Thursday, 20 people had been detained in connection with Tuesday's shooting in Sanliurfa.

The interior and education ministries held a joint school security meeting in the capital, Ankara, on Thursday, that was attended by both ministers and all 81 of Turkey's provincial governors, as well as police chiefs and provincial



education directors.

Turkey's national police headquarters revealed the suspect's profile picture on the messaging platform WhatsApp was a photo of Elliot Rodger, a college student who killed six people in California in 2014.

The Ministry of Family and Social Services announced Thursday it had set up a team to "provide psychosocial support" to students and their families. It also plans to conduct a comprehensive investigation of similar incidents. Funerals were held Thursday afternoon for each of the eight students, all age 11, who were killed Wednesday. Math teacher Ayla Kara (55) who died during the attack, also was buried Thursday.

Cevdet Yesil, whose son Adnan Gokturk Yesil was among the victims, said he rushed to the school Wednesday after being informed of the shooting.

"And unfortunately we searched for our child, our son, until 5 p.m. One way or another, our security forces found him," Yesil said. "We went to the hospital and identified (his remains). We saw he had died." (AP)

Kazakhstan convicts 19 activists over Xinjiang region protests

DAKE KANG
■ Beijing

A court in Kazakhstan convicted 19 activists after a protest against Beijing's crackdown in China's far-western Xinjiang region last year, in what experts and advocates said was the largest move yet by the Kazakh Government to silence criticism at Beijing's behest.

The activists, all of whom were Kazakh nationals, protested near the border with China in November, burning Chinese flags and portraits of Chinese leader Xi Jinping and calling for the release of a Kazakh citizen



detained in Xinjiang last year.

Eleven activists were sentenced to five years in prison for "inciting discord," while the other eight were given restrictions on their movement. Shinguat Baizhan, a lawyer representing the activists, confirmed the sentences, which

were also reported in local media. Though Kazakhs speaking out against China's policies in Xinjiang have long faced pressure, advocacy groups say this is the first time such a large group of Xinjiang activists has been imprisoned in the country. (AP)

New Research : Astronomers measure instant power of black hole jets

MARCIA DUNNAP
■ Cape Canaveral (US)

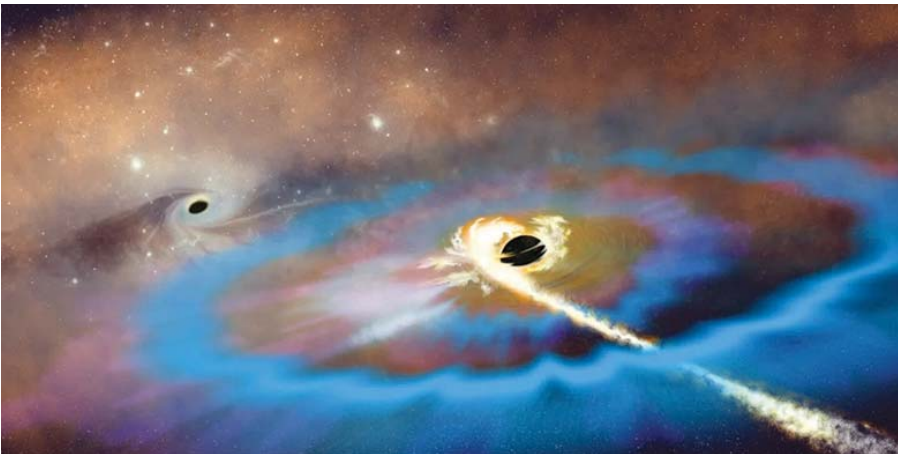
For the first time, scientists have measured the instantaneous mind-blowing power of jets blasting from a black hole. The jet power from this relatively close black hole-star system is equivalent to 10,000 suns, an international research team reported Thursday. They also tracked the jet speed: roughly 355 million mph (540 million kph) — half the speed of light.

Located 7,200 light-years away, Cygnus X-1 features not only a black hole — the first one ever identified more than a half-century ago - but a blue supergiant star, its constant companion. A light-

year is nearly 6 trillion miles (9.7 trillion kilometers).

The University of Oxford's Steve Prabu and his team based their findings on 18 years of high-resolution radio imaging obtained by a global telescope network. He conducted the research while still at Australia's Curtin University, which led the study published in Nature Astronomy.

Prabu and his colleagues were able to measure the swift power of these "dancing jets" as he calls them, as they were pushed in opposite directions by the star's wind. The group based its calculations on how much the jets were bent by the stellar wind as well as computer model-



ing. Until now, a black hole's jet power had to be averaged over tens of thousands of years, the researchers said.

Prabu said a key finding is that 10 per cent of all the energy released as matter falls toward the black hole is

carried away by the jets. On the skimpy side as black holes go, the one in Cygnus X-1 is continually pulling

Pope travels to Cameroon to preach peace Message



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Yaounde

Pope Leo XIV is travelling to the western Cameroon city of Bamenda to preach a message of peace in the epicentre of a separatist conflict that humanitarian groups have called one of the world's most neglected crises.

Leo is to preside over a peace meeting on Thursday involving a Mankon traditional chief, a Presbyterian moderator, an imam and a Catholic nun. The aim is to highlight the interfaith movement that has been seeking to end the conflict and care for its many traumatised victims. The pope is also set to celebrate a Mass for the people of Bamenda, located near Cameroon's western border with Nigeria. Leo arrived in Cameroon on Wednesday on the second leg

of his four-nation African trip, the first by the first American pope. In his arrival speech, he demanded that the "chains of corruption" in the mineral-rich country be broken and lectured President Paul Biya on the legitimate exercise of authority.

The 93-year-old Biya, the world's oldest leader, has been in power since 1982 and claims to have won a disputed election last year that gave him an eighth term in office. The conflict in Cameroon's two Anglophone regions is rooted in Cameroon's colonial history, when the country was divided between France and Britain after World War I. English-speaking regions later joined French Cameroon in a 1961 UN-backed vote, but separatists say they have since been politically and economically marginalised.

New York governor pitches new tax on pricey pied-a-terres



ANTHONY IZAGUIRRE
■ New York

For months, New York Governor Kathy Hochul has resisted calls to increase taxes on 6th the wealthy, beating back progressives who have hounded her from Manhattan to Puerto Rico bellowing chants of "tax the rich."

Now she is pitching a compromise. The moderate Democrat says she will push to create a new tax on multimillion-dollar second homes in New York City known as pied-a-terres, attempting to appease Mayor Zohran Mamdani and his supporters while also tending

to her concerns about destabilising the state's finances. The idea, announced Wednesday, would allow the city to impose a tax surcharge on secondary residences worth over \$5 million, with the governor's office saying it could generate at least \$500 million annually as Mamdani moves to fill a multibillion dollar budget hole and fund his ambitious agenda.

"As governor, I understand the importance of stabilising the city's finances without compromising on essential services New Yorkers count on," Hochul said in a statement. (AP)

Indian accused of cheating cultural organisation of over SGD 1.6 million

GURDIP SINGH
■ Singapore

An Indian national was among the two persons charged with cheating a cultural organisation of more than SGD 1.6 million (approximately \$1.3 million), according to a local media report.

Between April and December 2023, accused Alagappan Muthu, 53, and Chinese-origin Singaporean Ching Wai Leng, 81, allegedly conspired nine times to defraud Kwong Wai Siew Peck San Theng in Bishan, according to Channel News Asia. Kwong Wai Siew Peck San Theng is a cultural organisation and columbarium which



houses vaults lined with recesses for cinerary urns. Citing the Corrupt Practices Investigation Bureau (CPIB), the channel said, Ching was then the head of the maintenance section at the columbarium while Muthu was a director at KKV Construction, a private company.

Ching owned Asiabuild Enterprises, a company that

provided general construction and waterproofing services, and was also a director there, a CPIB release said.

The duo allegedly agreed to help KKV Construction secure jobs - including plastering, painting, washing and repair works - through an open tender. In return, Muthu's KKV Construction subcontracted the work to Asiabuild Enterprises.

By allegedly hiding these arrangements from the management committee, they misled the president of Kwong Wai Siew Peck San Theng into approving roughly SGD 16,61,785 (approximately \$3,08,224) in payments to KKV Construction. (PTI)

gases from its stellar playmate as they orbit one another. Discovered in the 1960s, the binary system is located in our Milky Way's Cygnus, or swan, constellation. The supergiant star feeds material to the black hole, giving it "something to eat" and launch as jets," Prabu said in an email.

These jets can help scientists better understand how black holes help shape galaxies and other cosmic structures through large-scale shocks and turbulence.

Prabu plans to apply similar techniques to other black holes. "It would be exciting to measure jet power in many more systems," he said. (AP)

PROSPECT

Army destroys bunkers and firing positions in Jalenbung Hills and Thoyee Heights

In continuation of ongoing operations astride NH-202, the Security Forces lead by Red Shield Division launched coordinated Joint Area Domination Patrols again in the general areas of Jalenbung hills and Thoyee Heights, aimed at maintaining security and preventing re-establishment of hostile infrastructure.

The operation commenced with two joint columns comprising teams from the Indian Army, CAPF and Manipur Police carrying out the operation on both sides of the highway respectively. In the Jalenbung Hills, a systematic sweep resulted in identification and subsequent destruction of multiple bunkers that had previously been dismantled but were found to be re-established.

A total of five such bunkers were destroyed in the area. Simultaneously, in Thoyee Heights, a series of bunkers along the Mahadev Hills and Thoyee Heights were identified, five repaired bunkers that had earlier been dismantled were destroyed again.

Overall, a total of ten bunkers were destroyed during the coordinated operation.

The operation underscores the continued synergised resolve of the Security Forces to deny any attempts at re-establishment of hostile firing positions, while ensuring peace and stability in the region through sustained and coordinated efforts.



West Asia Conflict: Inbound tourism dips 15-20 per cent

India's inbound tourist traffic declined 15-20 per cent since the West Asia crisis broke out, while the aviation industry is staring at an estimated net loss of ₹18,000 crore following disruptions caused by the conflict, according to a report on the impact of the West Asia conflict released on Thursday.

The report, titled "Impact of the West Asia Conflict on India's Tourism, Aviation & Hospitality Sectors", highlighted that the aviation sector was the most impacted, with airlines facing flight cancellations, airspace restrictions and significant rerouting of international flights.

These disruptions have increased flying time by 2-4 hours on key routes, resulting in a sharp rise in fuel consumption and operating costs.

Industry estimates indicate that fuel accounts for 35-40 per cent of airline operating costs, and the ongoing situation has further strained airline profitability. The disruption of West Asia air corridors, which is among the busiest global transit routes, has also reduced connectivity efficiency and increased airfares, the report said.

The overall industry impact, including the estimated ₹18,000 crore net loss, has been assessed by rating agency Ica by examining stakeholder feedback with sectoral trends, booking patterns, cancellations and operational cost pressures (particularly aviation-related), PHDCCI said.

India's inbound tourist traffic declined 15-20 per cent, particularly in leisure travel, as global travellers adopt a cautious approach amid geopolitical uncertainties, according to the report.

Delhi's EV charging infra registers record growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Electric Vehicle (EV) charging infra in Delhi has witnessed "record" expansion in the last one year with the total number of charging points rising to over 10,000, of which more than 3,000 were added in the past few months. Delhi's EV charging infra registers 'record' expansion; total charging points over 10,000

Delhi Power minister Ashish Sood said that the fast rise in the number of charging points in the city is an outcome of the policy-level clarity and speedier implementation under the new government.

"Under the draft EV policy of the government, there is special focus on expansion of charging infrastructure and we will ensure an adequate number of public charging stations to meet the growth



of electric vehicles in the city," he said.

Sood said that the Power department is working to strengthen power transmission and distribution infrastructure in Delhi to meet the rising charging demand which is likely to rise with implementation of the new EV policy.

As a committed partner to the Delhi government's vision of a 'Viksit Delhi', BSES

charging points and battery swapping stations across more than 3,400 locations in South, West, East and Central Delhi, he said.

These include 3,217 private charging points, followed by 2,870 public charging points, and 465 captive charging points, while 340 battery swapping stations account for 5 per cent of the network, he said.

Under the private category, connections are largely domestic connections which account for 50-60 per cent, RWAs or group housing societies 15-20 per cent, and commercial establishments 20-25 per cent, he added.

Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited discom that supplies electricity in North Delhi areas, has energised 3,783 EV connections as of now, out of which 1,641 EV connections got charged in 2025-26, said a company spokesperson.

The new connections include 42 for public charging stations and 15 for battery swapping stations, he said.

North Delhi areas, including Rohini, Pitampura, Civil Lines, Model Town, and Shalimar Bagh have emerged as key demand hubs, contributing to nearly 63 per cent of the total installations, while regions like Bawana, Narela, and Kirari present significant opportunities for future growth, he said.

"We aim to facilitate 3,000 additional EV charging stations in the coming year by providing the necessary power connections. The TPPDL believes that every electric mile driven is a step towards reducing pollution and creating a cleaner, greener future by providing reliable charging infrastructure," he added.

The total charging load in BSES areas stands at 227.48

MW and is projected to reach 375 MW over the next two years, reflecting rapid EV adoption, said the discom official. The EV charging load has surged from 24 MW in FY 2018-19 to over 227 MW today — a nearly nine times increase, he added.

According to the latest Central Electricity Authority report, released recently, Delhi accounts for 24.1 per cent of India's total EV public charging electricity consumption, with 239.63 million units out of 992.73 MUs nationally.

Delhi ranks first in India in EV charging electricity consumption, ahead of Maharashtra, Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh and Telangana, an official said.

In Delhi, BSES accounts for 124.20 MUs, contributing 52 per cent of the city's EV charging consumption and 12.5 per cent of national consumption, the person said.

Krishnavataram trailer ignites faith at Krishna Janmabhoomi in Mathura

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The trailer of Krishnavataram was unveiled at the sacred Krishna Janmabhoomi temple in Mathura, drawing thousands of devotees into a profound collective expression of faith. The gathering at Lord Krishna's birthplace transcended a mere cinematic launch, resonating deeply with the faithful.

The unveiling extended across key sacred sites including Raman Reti Temple, Radha Rani Temple, Prem Mandir, and ISKCON Vrindavan, turning the launch into a multi-location devotional movement.

The spectacular trailer is a beautiful deep dive into the grand and enchanting world of Lord Krishna.

Written by Prakash Kapadia and Raam Mori, the film features cinematography by Ayananka Bose, music by Prasad S, production design



by Chokkas Bhaardwaj, costumes by Nidhi Yasha, and lyrics by Irshad Kamil. Krishnavataram will be distributed globally by AA Films, with music released by Saregama.

Directed by Hardik Gajjar, Krishnavataram is presented and produced by Sajjan Raj Kurup and Shobha Sant

NBCC commemorates Ambedkar Jayanti, unveils sample flat at Greater Noida

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC commemorated the birth anniversary of Bharat Ratna Dr BR Ambedkar with great reverence at Leisure Valley, Greater Noida. Celebrated as Ambedkar Jayanti, the day holds immense significance as a tribute to the architect of the Indian Constitution and a champion of equality, justice and empowerment, whose ideals continue to guide the nation's progress. A heartfelt homage was paid to Baba Saheb, acknowledging his unparalleled contribution to nation-building and social justice.

The event was graced by the presence of R Venkataramani, Attorney General of India & Ld. Court Receiver (Amrapali Projects), Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, and Dr Suman Kumar, Director (Commercial), NBCC.

Senior officials and other dignitaries were also present during the ceremony.

Marking a significant milestone, NBCC also inaugurated a Sample Flat at Leisure Valley FAR Projects, Greater Noida, showcasing the quality and progress of ongoing development works.

In a gesture reflecting appreciation and inclusivity, Shramjeevies and their



children were felicitated during the event.

Recognising that children are the future of the nation and torchbearers of a progressive and inclusive India, gifts and tokens of appreciation were presented to encourage

their aspirations. This thoughtful initiative underscored the importance of nurturing young minds while honoring the invaluable contributions of the workforce in advancing the vision of a "Viksit Bharat."

DAILY SUDOKU

	7		5		9	
	3		8			2
9		8		3		
		2		9	5	7
	9		5	4		8
5	7	8		6		
		3		1		5
1		9			6	
	8		1		2	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

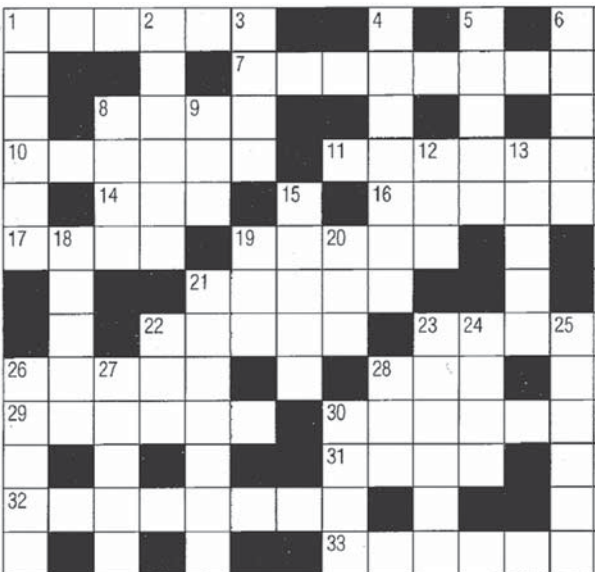
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (16.04.26)

2	5	3	6	7	1	4	9	8
8	6	4	9	5	3	7	1	2
1	7	9	2	4	8	6	3	5
9	8	1	4	6	5	3	2	7
7	4	6	3	8	2	9	5	1
5	3	2	7	1	9	8	6	4
6	9	8	5	2	4	1	7	3
4	2	7	1	3	6	5	8	9
3	1	5	8	9	7	2	4	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | APRIL 17, 2026



ACROSS

- When Uncle's on the plane, this is thrown out (6)
- No longer just one confusing sample (8)
- He's sat on in parts of Africa (4)
- Two names for an animal (6)
- Get somewhere with a car I have (6)
- The contractor's finished (3)
- Endlessly, Arsene manages to be more reasonable (5)
- Quadrupedal start turn (4)
- Lure of the month, to some boys (5)
- Numerically different from Arabic (5)

DOWN

- Vessel that travels (fruitfully?) by road (3,3)
- I's fuming, yes, in a terrible mess! (6)
- Food in from Ealing (4)
- Writer, possibly a mere boy! (7)
- Obvious intention to tour India (5)
- It blooms in a monastery garden (5)
- You'll find one in a Caledonian discotheque (4)
- Much reduced fare (3)
- He's brainy, using no bin! (3)
- Famous name never misspelt (5)
- The old-fashioned fellows abroad (5)
- Apportion everybody a share of the loot (5)

- He has to look around for a perfect ending (5)
- In a manner, I'm wrong on certain points (4)
- Is in the position to organise a posse (5)
- Neither is in ignorance (3)
- Reach for some meat, maybe a tin (6)
- Foreigner's wild anger about "Monsieur" (6)
- She's clearly big-hearted! (4)
- Men figure to come round and make a start (8)
- Did Cook sail in one? (6)

- The point of a website, say? (3)
- Also known as wheels (3)
- Lived with Sid, with wild deer around (7)
- Not much food, but a chick may take it (3)
- Code letter put in one's mouth (6)
- The fresh air around Maidenhead suits her (4)
- Number that has ten in, possibly, at the very end (6)
- Could start taking the path around a small area (5)
- Piece of sticky paper (5)
- A modern prefix (3)
- Like Tim, a courtly sportsman (4)

SOLUTION (16.04.26)

ACROSS	19. Error	DOWN	14. Gi-gue
1. Waifs	20. Drudge	2. Afr-aid	15. Peter
6. Match	22. Best	3. F-ought	16. Poets
9. O-atmeal	24. Sue 2	4. (pa-)Sad(Ena)	18. Bowel
10. Proud	5. Reports	6. Matador	19. E-G-g-head
11. Tawny	26. Wheel	7. Alanador	21. Runner
12. Me-g-an	27. A-nnie	8. Can't-er	22. B-ovine
13. Lighter	28. Ti-tan	9. Met-RE	23. St-RAF-e
15. Pep	29. F-action	12. Met-RE	25. Rents
17. Edit	30. Fr-E-ed	13. Leeds	26. W-I-fe
18. Bolero	31. Never		28. Ton

भोंडसी . नगर निगम . गुरुग्राम

Chandrashekhar Smriti Van

विकसित भारत 2047 : मनोहर लाल खट्टर

नायब सिंह सैनी

मनोहर लाल खट्टर

राम बहादुर राय

पी. एस. प्रसाद • प्रो. एच. एन. शर्मा

ट्रस्टी

भारत यात्रा ट्रस्ट, चंद्रशेखर स्मृति वन, भोंडसी, गुरुग्राम, हरियाणा

 BRIEFLY

Joshna, Chotrani advance in Hamburg Open



Veteran Joshna Chinappa and Veer Chotrani advanced in the Hamburg Open squash, while compatriots Velavan Senthilkumar and Tanvi Khanna bowed out in the opening round here.

Former women's world No 10 Joshna eased past local challenger Saskia Beinhard 11-4, 11-5, 11-4, while men's world No 47 Chotrani beat Spain's Ivan Perez 11-8, 11-9, 11-8 in the PSA Bronze-level event.

Men's fifth seed Abhay Singh, who moved up to a career-best world ranking of 22 this week, and Ramit Tandon, the seventh seed, received first-round byes.

Other Indian results - Men: R Tsukue (Jpn) bt V Senthilkumar 11-4, 11-9, 14-12; Women: Hannah Craig (Irl) bt Tanvi Khanna 11-5, 11-7, 13-11.

Liverpool forward Hugo Ekitike to miss World Cup



Liverpool striker Hugo Ekitike will miss the World Cup because of a serious leg injury, France coach Didier Deschamps confirmed Wednesday. Ekitike sustained a suspected Achilles tendon injury in the 27th minute of Tuesday's Champions League match between Liverpool and Paris Saint-Germain and was taken off the field on a stretcher. "The severity of his injury will unfortunately prevent him from finishing the season with Liverpool and from participating in the World Cup," Deschamps said. Serious Achilles injuries can take more than six months to fully recover from. Liverpool did not immediately confirm the news, but coach Arne Slot said Tuesday that the injury looked "really bad." Ekitike has been one of Liverpool's top players this season and was expected to be part of France's squad for the World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico. He has scored 19 goals for club and country and scored for France in its 2-1 win over Brazil last month.

"Hugo is one of about 10 young players who have made their debuts for the national team in recent months. He had integrated perfectly into the group, both on and off the pitch," Deschamps said. "This injury is a huge blow for him, obviously, but also for the French national team. His disappointment is immense. Hugo will get back to his best, I'm convinced of it. But I wanted to express my full support for him, as well as that of the entire staff."

Swiss coach fired over fake COVID certificate scandal

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Zurich

A Swiss hockey coach who admitted he used a certificate falsely claiming he'd been vaccinated against COVID-19 to get around China's travel restrictions for the 2022 Winter Olympics has been fired.

In a statement late Monday, head coach Patrick Fischer said he made a "serious mistake in this matter" by traveling to Beijing with the Switzerland men's team using false paperwork.

The Swiss Ice Hockey Federation initially supported him, saying the case was closed because he had admitted to his mistake. But that changed Wednesday with news of his dismissal.

"The case is legally closed but has triggered a public



debate about values and trust, which? the federation takes very seriously," federation president Urs Kessler said ?in a statement.

"From today's perspective, our initial assessment — that the matter was concluded — was too short-sighted. This is about values and respect, that are fundamental to Swiss Ice Hockey and which Patrick Fischer did not uphold in 2022."

Bayern Munich reach semis in Champions League

CIARAN FAHEY
■ Munich

Bayern Munich turned the tables on old rival Real Madrid. Luis Diaz and Michael Olise scored late for the Bavarian powerhouse to beat Madrid 4-3 and advance to the Champions League semifinals on Wednesday.

In the last four two-legged ties between the sides, the Spanish giant had prevailed each time.

The second-leg quarterfinal game ended in acrimony with Madrid's players furious that referee Slavko Vincic sent off substitute Eduardo Camavinga in the 86th minute with a second yellow card for an innocuous challenge on Harry Kane.

Diaz fired inside the right post three minutes later and Olise ended the contest definitively with a spectacular strike in stoppage time to give Bayern a 6-4 win on aggregate after the Bavarian powerhouse won the first leg of their quarterfinal 2-1 in Madrid last week.

Madrid's players surrounded Vincic after the game. Arda Guler, who scored two brilliant goals to spark the visitors' hopes of



a famed "remontada" (comeback), was shown a red card for his vehement complaints.

"Everything was over with the red card," Madrid coach Alvaro Arbeloa said of

Camavinga's sending off. "It's unbelievable. You cannot send off a player for this action."

Bayern will play defending champion Paris Saint-Germain in the semifinals.

Also Wednesday, Arsenal advanced past Sporting Lisbon to set up a last-four showdown against Atletico Madrid.

Blistering start in Munich: Guler opened the scoring after just 34 seconds thanks to a mistake from Bayern goalkeeper Manuel Neuer   " who was outstanding in the first leg   " whose attempted pass went straight to the 21-year-old Turkey star, who fired the ball into the empty net from distance.

Bayern seemed unfazed and Aleksandar Pavlovic equalized with a point-blank header from a Joshua Kimmich corner in the sixth minute. Bayern maintained its dominance with Madrid patiently looking for breaks.

Konrad Laimer did well to block Kylian Mbappe, who had an adhesive bandage above his right eye after getting a heavy blow to his face last weekend.

Guler beat Neuer with a brilliant free kick in the 29th, but Bayern had legitimate complaints it should not have been awarded with Brahim Diaz going down after minimal contact from Laimer.

Messi accused of breaching \$7 million Florida friendly deal

MARIA SHERMAN
■ Miami

Lionel Messi is being sued by a Miami-based event promoter who says the soccer icon violated terms of a \$7 million contract by missing an exhibition match last year.

Vid Music Group filed the lawsuit for fraud and breach of contract against Messi and the Argentine Football Association in Miami-Dade circuit court last month, according to court records.

Messi and the AFA didn't immediately respond to messages seeking comment.

Considered one of the greatest soccer players ever, Messi appears with both his Major League Soccer club Inter Miami and Argentina's national team, and fans routinely pay much higher prices for the chance to see him play. (AP)



Real Madrid coach Arbeloa slams referee's inexplicable decision to send off Camavinga

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Munich

Real Madrid coach Alvaro Arbeloa slammed referee Slavko Vincic's "inexplicable" decision to send off Eduardo Camavinga toward the end of Bayern Munich's 4-3 win in the Champions League on Wednesday.

Vincic blew the whistle for a foul after Bayern forward Harry Kane went down under minimal contact from Camavinga and clutched his shin as if in pain. Vincic then showed the Madrid substitute his second yellow card, but appeared to forget that he'd booked him already. He was reminded by Bayern players including Jamal Musiala, Joshua Kimmich, and Aleksandar Pavlovic, and subsequently sent the player off.

Luis Diaz scored three



minutes later to equalise at 3-3 on the night, putting Bayern 5-4 up on aggregate, before Michael Olise made sure of the win in stoppage time, giving Bayern a 6-4 win over two legs.

"Everything was over with the red card," Arbeloa said. "It's unbelievable. You cannot send off a player for this action. It's not fair in a

match like that, and well, we are very, very upset, very angry, but also congratulations to Bayern Munich."

Arda Guler scored twice and Kylian Mbappe scored the other as Madrid threatened a comeback after losing the first leg of the quarterfinal 2-1 in Madrid last week.

Arbeloa said the sending

off was "completely inexplicable and unfair."

"The tie slipped away from us in a way that was beyond our control, and I feel terrible for my players, for the effort they put in," he said.

"I'm very proud of them, of the fans, of everyone who traveled, of those at home, and of the club. What hurts most about this defeat is that we won't win the sixteenth (European title) this year, and — above all — because of the way it happened."

Madrid faces the prospect of a second consecutive season without a trophy as it trails Barcelona by nine points in La Liga with seven rounds remaining and was knocked out of the Spanish Cup by second-division side Albacete Balompie in January.

From Masters to Heritage: Golf's quick turn to Hilton Head

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Hilton Head Island (USA)

Two golf tournaments separated by one week and 150 miles (240 kilometers) could not be any more different. The Masters is the first major of the year, a high-stress test at Augusta National that requires full attention on just about every shot because of the razor-thin difference in the outcome. The RBC Heritage provides a tight, tree-lined Harbour Town course that oozes a sense of peace.

The winner gets a green jacket one week, a plaid one the next.

And there was one other element that made Cameron Young look forward to the week after being in contention at Augusta National.

"It is easier, physically, like the walk," Young said after finishing nine holes of a pro-am round. "And staying closer. Everything seems simpler." Otherwise, it's time to move on amid a reminder there is no time to stop to rest.

Masters champion Rory McIlroy chose not to play this \$20 million signature event, not a surprise because he didn't play last year, either. Tiny, tight Harbour Town is one that doesn't quite fit him. Justin Rose also pulled out, fresh off his third time with a lead on the back nine at Augusta National without a green jacket to show for it.

The PGA Tour is in the early stages of a six-week stretch that includes two majors and three \$20 million signature events.

The Masters is over. They're on



to Hilton Head.

"It's over with. Can't really go back," said Scottie Scheffler, who had reason to replay the final round in his mind in the three days between tournaments.

He was 12 shots behind going into the weekend at the Masters and finished one behind McIlroy despite making only one birdie on the par 5s on the back nine all week.

"So if I would be frustrated, it would be with the start," Scheffler said. "But I'm proud of how I played on the weekend. That's part of the beauty and frustrating part of golf — I get to try again this week. And if I had won last week, it would be the same thing."

He speaks from experience. The last time Scheffler won the Masters in 2024, he came to the RBC Heritage and won by three shots.

IGPL Golf: Olympian Mane shares early lead with Soni and Shah

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

Olympian Udayan Mane, searching for his maiden win at the IGPL Invitational South Africa here, got off to a bogey-free start and was tied for the lead with two others at 7-under 65 at the end of the first day.

Mane was sharing the lead with Milind Soni and Manav Shah, and the trio were one clear off the field. There was a big bunch snapping at their heels as six others were within two shots of them.

The crowded leaderboard saw last year's IGPL Rankings winner Pukhraj Singh Gill (66) one behind at sole fourth, while Gaganjeet Bhullar, the 11-time Asian Tour winner, the in-form Karandeep Kochhar and the upcoming Saarthak Chhibber were all tied fifth at 5-under 67.



In the team contest, the 7-under cards by co-leaders Shah and Soni, ensured Green Fuels Hyderabad were on the top at 14-under, while

Honer Gurugram with Pukhraj Gill (66) and Shat Mishra (69) were second at 9-under.

Krishna Punjab was helped

by Kochhar (67) and Harendra Gupta (69) into the third place at 8-under.

Sachin Baisoya, who ended his IGPL title drought last week in Mauritius, was sole eighth at 4-under 68, which included an eagle on the ninth. Seven players, including two locals, were tied for the ninth spot at 3-under 69 at the iconic Royal Johannesburg Golf Club's West Course.

The five Indians were Raghav Chugh, Shat Mishra, Harendra Gupta, Ranjit Singh and left-hander Kartik Sharma, while the two locals at T-9 with them were Allister de Kock and Musiwalo Nethunzwi.

The top women in the field after day one were Vidhatri Urs and Vani Kapoor, who carded even par 72 each. Both had two birdies and two bogeys each.

The Masters is a "high-stress test" at Augusta National Golf Club, while the RBC Heritage at Harbour Town Golf Links offers a calmer, tighter course

He is known to put winning - and losing - behind him quickly. The difference this week was the time he invested getting ready.

"The preparation looks a little different in terms of not doing nearly as much as a normal week," he said. "That's mainly because this golf course doesn't change too much. Rest is a huge part of that."

The field is the largest for the signature events, 82 players because of 10 additional players who won in 2025 and did not get to play The Sentry at Kapalua because it was canceled by a dispute over water.

Young had just as good of a chance to win as Scheffler, and

that was on his mind when he drove three hours through the Low Country of South Carolina to the next destination. He had eight straight chances at birdie on the back nine at the Masters and finished with nine straight pars.

"I had a really good chance to win, and I played the golf to win," Young said. "I just didn't, which happens a lot in golf. But I think about all the times Rosey has played the golf to win and hasn't, or even Rory. It does happen."

What he enjoyed about the week in retrospect was being in the final group, leading by two shots on the front nine. Young was thinking about having a chance a month before the Masters. (AP)

Punjab Kings crush Mumbai Indians

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Prabhsimran Singh and Shreyas Iyer struck fluent fifties as Punjab Kings' winning run continued with a seven-wicket hammering of Mumbai Indians, who suffered a fourth consecutive defeat in the Indian Premier League here on Thursday.

Even as Quinton de Kock, with a brilliant 112 not out, and Naman Dhir (50) bailed Mumbai Indians out in the first half with a robust 132-run third-wicket stand, the hosts' 195/6 was never challenging enough on a docile track against the rampant Punjab batters.

Prabhsimran made a wicketless Jasprit Bumrah (0/41) and MI pay for a regulation drop early, smashing a strokeful 80 not out off 31 balls (11x4s, 2x6s), while skipper Iyer was in his elements, notching up his third fifty in as many outings with a 66 off 35 balls (5x4s, 4x6s), as the duo stitched a sturdy 139-run stand for the third wicket.

Chasing 196, PBKS went over the line with 21 balls to spare, scoring 198/3 as MI bowlers continued to disappoint collectively, with AM Ghazanfar's 2/31 being the only performance of note.

Punjab were quick off the blocks as the first over from Deepak Chahar yielded 21 runs, putting MI on the backfoot.

A pivotal moment arrived in the third over when Bumrah, placed at short third, spilled a regulation chance off Hardik Pandya when Prabhsimran was only on 11.

Ghazanfar dismissed Priyansh Arya (15) and Cooper Connolly (17) to give Mumbai two elusive wickets in the powerplay, but the hosts could



Prabhsimran Singh celebrating his half century at Wankhede Stadium in Mumbai PTI

never capitalise on those breakthroughs.

Prabhsimran unleashed his rich repertoire of strokes, hitting a flurry of fours, while Iyer relished batting on his home track of the Wankhede Stadium, dispatching the bad balls with ease.

Their 139-run stand came from only 67 balls as Prabhsimran and Iyer eclipsed the first-innings heroics of de Kock and Dhir.

In the 16th over, a powerful pull from Iyer went through Dhir's hands for a six and the Punjab skipper sent the next from Shardul Thakur flying into the stands. However, a flick off the pads in the air gave Dhir another chance, which he converted with a fine diving catch in the front.

Earlier, a belligerent century from Quinton de Kock (112 not out) and a gritty 50 from Naman Dhir pulled MI out of doldrums and lifted them to an under-par 195/6.

Confined to warming the bench so far, de Kock replaced Rohit Sharma and smacked his third IPL hundred to lead an inspirational fightback for the troubled Mumbai Indians, who had slipped to 15/2 in three overs.

The veteran Protea batter was in his elements during his unbeaten ton — a 60-ball 112 not out (8x4s, 7x6s) and his first in IPL since 2022 — clobbering the ball powerfully on the leg-side and picking boundaries with precision and terrific timing on the off.

Arshdeep Singh (3/22) swung the

ball precariously and bowled immaculate lengths to snaffle two key wickets early on, while a third came late in the innings.

After beating Ryan Rickelton (2) persistently with deliveries that swung away, Arshdeep had the South African caught at deep square leg on a shortish ball. He was then all over India T20I skipper Suryakumar Yadav (0), luring him outside off on the first ball and beating him with the swing to have a thick edge flying to short third.

With Suryakumar back in the hut and Tilak Varma (8) out of sorts, MI took a punt in promoting Dhir at No. 4 and the right-handed batter repaid the faith with a gutsy knock.

Dhir was also lucky when on 10, as Yuzvendra Chahal spilled a sitter at short fine-leg off Marco Jansen in the fifth over. He was lucky again when a misjudgement in calling for a single in the next over did not result in de Kock being run-out at the non-striker's end, as Shreyas Iyer missed the direct hit.

De Kock and Dhir put on 132 off 68 balls in a robust third-wicket stand which not only revived MI but built a strong platform to push on for a big total, but the hosts could not manage one.

With a strong bottom-hand stroke play, Dhir struck three sixes and as many fours and played a perfect second fiddle to de Kock.

In the 18th over, Iyer had his arms spread wide in celebration after he caught the ball off Hardik Pandya (14) while being airborne over ropes at long-on and hurling it to Xavier Bartlett for a superbly-executed catch. (PTI)

Vaishali's quiet confidence, mother's presence her biggest strengths in World Championship quest

AJAI MASAND ■ New Delhi

The newly-crowned Candidates champion R Vaishali, a soft-spoken and unassuming presence often seen with her mother by her side, stands out for her quiet intensity, shaped by strong values and a grounded upbringing, the kind of Indian sportsperson who lets her game do the talking.

What truly shapes her is the ecosystem she comes from — a deeply committed chess family that has quietly nurtured excellence without seeking the spotlight, and in that understated, almost self-effacing journey lies her greatest strength.

On Wednesday, Vaishali, the lowest-rated player in the eight-woman field at the Candidates tournament in Paphos, Cyprus, let her quiet game do the talking, springing a fine victory over Kateryna Lagno to seal a place in the World Championship showdown against Ju Wenjun later this year.

For long, Vaishali, 24, had lived in the shadow of her younger and more celebrated brother, R Pragganandhaa, who had qualified for the Open section of the Candidates tournament, but a string of underwhelming performances knocked him out of contention early in the 14-round competition, ending his hopes of challenging D Gukesh for the world title



later this year. Even after Pragganandhaa's chances faded, the spotlight never quite turned to Vaishali, who is deeply close to her brother and would have felt his disappointment, perhaps even her own dip in morale.

But the quiet presence of her mother, always by their side in a saree and with a calm, unreadable expression, seemed enough to steady her and remind her that not all was lost. With 8.5 points, she sealed the title this time, a step up from last year in Toronto when Vaishali had qualified for the Candidates but finished joint second, narrowly missing out on a shot at the World Championship.

Silence and few words have long been her forte, shaped in a middle-class household where her father worked as a bank branch manager and her mother was a homemaker.

Vaishali, who became only the third Indian woman Grandmaster after Koneru Humpy and D Harika in

December 2023, quietly rose through the ranks. She collected age-group titles in plenty and earned her International Master title in 2021, before stepping into the spotlight at the Chess Olympiad in Mamallapuram, Chennai in 2022, where she clinched a historic individual bronze and also helped the team secure a bronze. In Cyprus, that same quiet confidence held firm, even with her cast as the underdog. She did have momentum on her side, having qualified for the Candidates by winning the FIDE Women's Grand Swiss tournament in 2025 just as she had in 2023. But in a field packed with heavyweights like Norway Chess champion Anna Muzychuk, women's World Rapid champion Aleksandra Goryachkina, world blitz champion Bibisara Assaubayeva, and two of China's finest in Zhu Jiner and Tan Zhongyi, the odds were anything but in her favour. (PTI)

Blow for CSK as Khaleel Ahmed ruled out with injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Chennai Super Kings pacer Khaleel Ahmed has been ruled out of the IPL due to a quadriceps injury.

Ahmed, who was part of all the five games CSK have played thus far, reported pain in his right hip during the previ-

ous game against KKR on April 14. He was one of the consistent performers for CSK in the initial stage of the tournament.

"It is a grade 2 tear and the rehab will take at least 10-12 weeks," said an IPL source. The left arm pacer has played 11 ODIs and 18 T20s for India with the last appearance coming in July 2024.

Arjun, Aditya win another gold at the US Open



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Arjun Singh combined with Aditya Singh to win the men's doubles 5.0 event at the US Open Pickleball Championship by getting the better of J Meode and W Lin 9-11, 11-2, 11-7 in the final in Naples, Florida.

Another Indian pair to bag a medal was Panth Thakkar and Atharva Sheth, who took home a silver in the 4.5 men's doubles category, after losing the summit clash to Caian Appel and Michael Van Dusen

8-11, 9-11.

"Winning another gold at the US Open is very rewarding and to do it together once again, makes it extra special. We will continue to work hard to repeat these results with the support of our family and everyone around us," said Arjun Singh and Aditya Singh.

This is Arjun's third gold at the tournament and his second with his brother Aditya.

They had won the U18 boys doubles title earlier in the tournament.

KKR search for answers amid turmoil; in-form Gujarat Titans eye first home win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

An under pressure Kolkata Knight Riders would be hoping to arrest their steep slide against a resurgent Gujarat Titans in the Indian Premier League here on Friday.

Under captain Ajinkya Rahane and coach Abhishek Nayar, KKR have struggled for clarity, slumping to four defeats in five matches and still searching for their first win of the season.

It's their misfortune that their bowling had weakened significantly before the tournament following the injury setbacks to Harshit Rana and Akash Deep and the release of Mustafizur Rahman on BCCI instructions.

But the bigger concern was the dip in form of their spin mainstays Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravarthy. The Indian spinner is still in the struggle phase and is yet to take a wicket this season.

KKR's problems have also been compounded by questionable decisions on and off the field decisions.



Leaving out players like Tim Seifert and Rachin Ravindra have raised eyebrows, while their choices after winning the toss have been baffling.

In the rain-hit washout against Punjab Kings, Rahane surprised everyone by choosing to bat, while against Chennai Super Kings he opted to bowl first on a surface that clearly favoured the bowlers.

Their first match defeat to

Mumbai Indians after failing to defend 220 set the tone, and the heavy 65-run loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad at home only deepened the slide.

Since then, KKR have looked a side short on direction. Much of the spotlight was on Cameron Green, bought for a record Rs 25.20 crore to fill the void left by Andre Russell.

The Australian all-rounder has struggled to justify that

price tag, managing just 56 runs in five innings and making limited impact with the ball after being cleared to bowl.

The batting order, too, has looked confusing.

Sunil Narine was pushed up to open in their chase of 193, while Rahane, who has his best strike-rate in the power play, dropped to No 3, and neither move worked as KKR managed only 160/7 against CSK.

Bhagat replaces injured Atharva in MI squad

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Mumbai Indians on Thursday named Krish Bhagat as a replacement for injured Atharva Ankolekar for the remainder of the Indian Premier League.

Krish, the 21-year-old right-handed all-rounder who represents Punjab, brings versatility as a right-arm fast bowler and can

contribute with the bat as a lower order batsman.

He was part of Mumbai Indians trials for the past two years, having played for the Reliance in the DY Patil T20 cup in 2026 and has been a support bowler with the team since pre-season this year.



"Krish has consistently impressed the coaching staff with his dedication, work ethic, and

the quality he brings to every session and practise games that he played for Mumbai Indians," said Mumbai Indians in a statement.

"His commitment and development over the years, both in domestic and at Mumbai Indians practise sessions this season have earned him this well-deserved opportunity to transition into the main squad."

Kiran Powar to launch multi-sports facility

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Former first-class cricketer and coach Kiran Powar will launch a world-class multi-sports facility near Mumbai and Pune.

Located in Khopoli and spread across 55 acres, the facility aims to nurture young talent while promoting recreational sports and active lifestyles.

A badminton complex, Olympic-sized swimming pool and skating rink are already operational, while a cricket ground (July-August) and other facilities such as padel and squash courts, athletics track and open-air gym are in the pipeline, according to a release.

Indoor options like table tennis and chess are also planned.

After Ganguly, Watson joins hands with AI coaching platform Kabuni

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Kabuni, an AI-powered sports technology platform redefining cricket training, on Thursday appointed former Australian all-rounder Shane Watson as one of its "Super Coaches".

Former India captain Sourav Ganguly had joined hands with the UK based start up last year. "This collaboration brings together Kabuni's cutting-edge technology with Watson's deep cricketing

expertise, creating a powerful blend of data-driven insights and real-world experience for aspiring cricketers," said Kabuni in a statement.

The coaching platform is designed to transform traditional net practice by capturing player movement and ball tracking in real time, translating it into simple, actionable feedback.

"With its unique 'one per cent improvement' approach, the system focuses on small, immediate corrections that lead to meaningful performance gains over time.



Govt to criminalise administration of prohibited substances: Mandaviya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday said government is working towards a legislation that would criminalise trafficking and administration of prohibited performance-enhancing substances to athletes.

Speaking at the World Anti-Doping Agency's Global Anti-Doping Intelligence and Investigations Network (GAIIN) Final Conference here, the minister said India, which has topped the global list of dope offenders for the past three years, would aggressively tackle



the menace that casts a massive shadow on its aspirations of hosting the Olympics in 2036.

"We are working on introducing criminal provisions for athlete support staff or other

persons involved in trafficking and administering banned substances," Mandaviya said, making it apparent that coaches who are found encouraging use of banned substances by athletes would be among

those at the receiving end.

Currently, India does not have penal provisions to tackle supply of banned substances to athletes and disciplinary action is limited to bans that can last up to a lifetime depending on the degree of the offence.

"Doping is no longer individual conduct. It is organised multi-national enterprise. The threat of doping undermines sport as India becomes a global sporting hub. Regulations are not enough. Ethics and values are at the core of sports but growing pressure of competition can lead to doping," Mandaviya stressed.